Domesticating Politics:
How Religiously Conservative Parties Mobilize Women in India

May 13, 2026

Abstract

How do religiously conservative parties mobilize women despite supporting traditional gender norms that confine them to the private sphere? I develop a theory of norm-abiding mobilization (NAM) to explain this puzzle. When women's political participation is socially costly, parties can encourage participation by aligning activism with prevailing gender norms. Focusing on India's BJP, I show that presenting political engagement as a religious ideal of selfless service associated with feminine duty and care (*seva*) increases women's participation. Using qualitative fieldwork, text analysis, activist surveys, and ethnographically informed experiments, I demonstrate that the BJP deploys NAM more than secular parties. NAM works by making participation feel personally appropriate to women and socially acceptable to domestic gatekeepers, with the latter more consequential when patriarchal norms are binding. These findings shed light on women's political incorporation and the role of traditional norms in sustaining conservative movements.

Word count: 9,903

1 Introduction

How parties expand is fundamental to understanding political development when legitimacy depends on popular support. While incorporating new constituencies offers electoral advantage, expansion is politically and organizationally costly. It can provoke backlash from core voters, dilute ideological coherence, and strain organizational capacity. Sociological theories (Lipset and Rokkan 1967) emphasize parties as rooted in durable cleavages constraining diversification. Instrumentalist theories (Downs 1957) depict expansion as a strategy to capture median voters, but caution against diluting party brands and identities (Lupu 2014). Organizational and institutional legacies further limit flexibility (Panebianco 1988; Levitsky 2003; Tavits 2013), and the nature of party-voter linkages shapes the costs of outreach (Kitschelt 2000).

This article examines a hard case of party expansion: how religiously conservative parties espousing patriarchal norms mobilize women. Strategic imperatives increasingly require such organizations to incorporate women (Weeks et al. 2022; Nielsen 2020) even as they treat women's participation as ideologically suspect or socially disruptive (Thomas et al. 2023; Williams 2023; Celis and Childs 2018; Lovenduski and Norris 1993). These tensions are especially acute in societies where traditional norms relegate women to the private sphere, and women's political action challenges gender hierarchies. Nevertheless, conservative parties across diverse contexts have successfully integrated women (Cavdar 2022; Castillo 2022; Wiliarty 2010; Pugh 1988).

In this context, India saw a remarkable increase in women's participation. Between 1996 and 2014, women's engagement in party activities increased tenfold.[1] But not all parties gained equally. Paradoxically from a liberal perspective, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)—notwithstanding its ideology of *Hindutva* (Hindu-ness) that ties women to traditional domestic roles (Sarkar 1993; Bacchetta 2004)—outperformed its secular and liberal counterparts in mobilizing women (Figure A.1). This success is especially striking in a context where politics is labeled "dirty," "corrupt," and "masculine" (Jensenius 2019; Jakimow 2023), and where women's activism in public spaces provokes domestic and social backlash, threatening both personal and family reputations (Brulé 2020; Cheema et al. 2021; Prillaman 2023).

Although particularly visible, women's participation for religiously conservative parties is not uniquely Indian. In Turkey, Erdoğan labeled the AKP's women's wing as the "world's largest women's organization" (Cavdar 2022). Ethnographies from Lebanon, Israel, Palestine,

[1] National Election Studies, CSDS Delhi.

and Yemen document similar activism (Deeb 2011; Ben Shitrit 2015; Clark 2004), and survey experiments from the region reveal voters' openness to women candidates when stereotype-congruent (Lust and Benstead 2024). Moreover, conservative parties in the West—Weimar-era Catholic and right-wing parties, UK Tories, and US Republican women's clubs—created civic spaces for women before others (Sneeringer 2003; Pugh 1988; Rymph 2006). These cases raise a broader question: how do religiously conservative parties mobilize women while preserving ideological coherence and avoiding backlash?

I develop a theory of *norm-abiding mobilization* (NAM) to explain this paradox. When patriarchal norms militate against women's political participation, religiously conservative parties can enable entry not by challenging these norms, but by aligning political action with them. The BJP exemplifies this strategy by framing politics as *seva*, a religious and gendered norm of selfless service that maps onto domestic caregiving. This norm-abiding framing renders women's activism consistent with traditional notions of femininity. This in turn reduces reputational costs to women and families, and eases domestic resistance to women's public engagement.

I test this argument through a two-step multi-method approach. I begin by comparing the use of norm-abiding frames in the BJP with secular parties using qualitative fieldwork, social media analysis, and primary surveys with women activists. I then estimate the causal effect of these frames on women's participation using ethnographically-informed experiments embedded in a paired-respondent survey of 1,457 households.

The evidence from these methods converges to a consistent conclusion: the BJP employs norm-abiding mobilization more than secular parties, and women's participation increases when politics is framed accordingly. This operates through two channels: a *motivational* path that works through women, and, perhaps more proximately—given the structural constraints on women's participation—a *justification* path that facilitates gatekeepers' assent. These findings move beyond existing preference-based accounts attributing women's support for conservatism to religiosity (Duverger 1955; Moghadam and Kaftan 2019; Emmenegger and Manow 2014; Shorrocks 2018) or instrumental incentives (Blaydes and Linzer 2008) to highlight how patriarchal gatekeeping shapes women's political options by defining the boundaries of legitimate engagement.

This article makes theoretical and methodological contributions to the study of political participation, gender, religion, and parties. First, it addresses the understudied puzzle of why women support conservative parties. It does so by broadening the concept of participation beyond voting or candidacy to include informal grassroots engagement that constitutes the organizational bedrock of politics in India and beyond (Cruz and Tolentino 2019). Second, it theorizes the processes driving participation by bridging household-level (Cheema et al. 2021; Burns et al. 2001; Iversen and Rosenbluth 2010; Prillaman 2023) and party-level constraints (Lawless and Fox 2005; Preece et al. 2016). By formalizing how these private and public spheres *interact*, the article argues gatekeepers need not block participation, but redirect it such that it avoids challenging gender hierarchies.

Third, it links institutional and behavioral approaches to clarify how religion shapes conservative mobilization. While existing work emphasizes ideology, identity, and rhetoric (Grzymala-Busse 2012; Kalyvas 1996; McClendon and Riedl 2019; Jung 2020), this study highlights how religiously grounded norms and moral framing enable gendered mobilization. In doing so, it extends accounts of conservative expansion beyond Western contexts by foregrounding gender as a central yet understudied cross-cutting cleavage, one that parties can deploy to mitigate competing divisions of caste and class.

Finally, this article provides a practical illustration of multi-method research that triangulates qualitative theory-building with experimental techniques for causal inference. Deep fieldwork revealed *seva* embodied moral meanings beyond material service, shaping acceptable ideas of women's roles in public life. These insights informed experimental design, interpretation, and mechanisms through which NAM operates. In doing so, it illustrates how immersive qualitative work can contextualize causal inference.

The article proceeds as follows: I first elaborate the theory and trace the roots of NAM as operationalized through *seva* in Hindu nationalism. I then describe the cultural and institutional setting of Rajasthan, India's largest state (by area) and my research site. Subsequent empirical sections compare the BJP and secular party mobilization, present experimental tests to show the effectiveness of NAM, and unpack underlying mechanisms. I conclude by reflecting on the wider applicability of NAM, and implications for party politics and gendered political participation.

2 A Theory of Norm-abiding Mobilization

This article examines women's participation, understood as women's entry into the public sphere through party-created avenues. These include spaces in which parties mobilize women into public electoral activity (rallies, meetings, canvassing, and fundraising), through non-electoral activities ranging from contentious protests to non-contentious religious, cultural, and social service events.

Though less studied than turnout and candidacy, these intermediate forms are consequential for both women and parties. From women's perspective, partisan activism is socially costly. Its visibility transgresses the gendered boundary between private and public spheres, exposing women to reputational sanction and gatekeeper resistance. Yet, participation also builds the civic skills and networks that serve as pathways to deeper engagement. From a party perspective, grassroots networks are sustained through non-electoral organizing between elections, making it particularly consequential for the BJP which operates within a social movement whose long-term success hinges on generating broad public consensus around a wider ideological project (Jaffrelot 1996).

2.1 *The Costs of Norm-Deviance*

Gender and politics research consistently documents a gender gap in participation. Explanations range from individual disparities in socioeconomic resources, labor force participation, political interest and ambition, to party recruitment strategies (Brady et al. 1995; Schlozman et al. 1994; Inglehart and Norris 2003; Burns et al. 2001; Iversen and Rosenbluth 2006; Lawless and Fox 2005; 2010). Contemporary research builds on this to highlighting intra-household gendered power relations and patriarchal social norms (Gottlieb 2016; Brulé 2020; Cheema et al. 2022; Prillaman 2023). Moreover, when politics is considered a male domain, women's participation can be costly for women and their families.

Understanding gender mobilization therefore, requires attention to the normative costs of participation. In patriarchal contexts, women's grassroots activism challenges prescriptive norms relegating women to the home.[2] This can disrupt household hierarchies and threaten gatekeepers' authority. These costs can be severe: withholding information, withdrawing permission, and even physical punishment.[3]

Participation also carries broader social costs. Women activists often face scrutiny over conduct with fears of gossip and "character assassination" looming large (Jensenius 2019). Moreover, when family honor is embedded in women's reputations, these costs spill over to kin and community. Public visibility makes highlights transgressions making them easier to detect, thereby giving families stronger incentives to restrict women's mobility and political involvement.

[2] See Bicchieri (2005) for a distinction between norms as beliefs about actual action (descriptive) and appropriate action (prescriptive).

[3] 51% of Indian women considered it acceptable for husbands to physically punish wives for leaving home without permission (IHDS 2011).

Furthermore, political engagement may impose internal costs. Women who have absorbed prevailing norms may experience dissonance or unease when participation feels role-incongruent, leading to self-censorship or withdrawal, especially when their preferences are distinct or undervalued (Khan 2021). Even well-intentioned efforts can backfire when they violate social norms (Gottlieb 2016). Together, mobilization depends not only persuading women, but also on reducing the internal and external costs of sanction.

2.2 Reducing the Costs of Deviance

How can these costs be reduced? Existing research emphasizes two pathways: norm change (Weldon 2011; Htun and Weldon 2012), and correcting misperceived norms (Bursztyn et al. 2020; Tankard and Paluck 2016). I highlight a third, less-studied but widely used route: norm realignment. Here, political entrepreneurs or participants of their own accord use normatively congruent frames to align participation with prevailing gender expectations.[4]

Psychological research treats frames as equivalence devices that shift evaluation without altering the underlying meaning or activity (Tversky and Kahneman 1981; Chong and Druckman 2007; Iyengar 1994; Kinder and Sanders 1990). Drawing instead on social movement theory and cognitive linguistics, I treat frames as constitutive (Snow et al. 1986; Benford and Snow 2000; Goffman 1974; Fillmore 2006). Frames embed participation within cultural repertoires that shape its social meaning for participants and observers. Norms are particularly effective framing tools. As shared behavioral standards, they reduce cognitive effort by signaling shared expectations and appropriate action (Bicchieri 2017; White et al. 2009; Prentice and Paluck 2020). Simultaneously, they activate moral emotions to reinforce compliance (Prinz 2006; Nichols 2002). When political actors invoke norms, they reduce transaction costs of mobilization by building common knowledge and facilitating coordination.

Building on this logic, I formulate a theory of norm-abiding mobilization (NAM). The model has three actors: (1) parties, which supply frames that define the terms of participation; (2) women, who decide whether to engage given anticipated costs; and (3) domestic gatekeepers, usually male kin and elders with authority over women's mobility as conceptualized by Cheema et al. (2022). Gatekeepers mediate access, enforce norms, and face reputational costs from

[4]While not explicitly labeling this as norm realignment, several accounts show how women's initial entry into the public sphere is by reframing politics as aligned with traditional gender norms. See (amongst others) Minault (1982); Forbes (1988); Chatterjee (1989) for India, Higginbotham (1994); Skocpol (1995); Teele (2018) for US, and Franceschet et al. (2016) for Latin America.

women's public actions. Here, women are constrained agents: they hold preferences over participation but exercising them requires gatekeeper approval.

For analytic clarity, I distinguish between two stylized frames. Norm-abiding frames present participation as aligned with conventionally feminized roles such as motherhood, care-work, and community service. Norm-challenging frames, by contrast, mobilize women as autonomous, rights-bearing actors whose participation unsettles existing gender hierarchies. Parties deploying NAM are more likely to channel women toward decentralized, community-embedded arenas (service camps, religious and cultural gatherings, neighborhood welfare drives) where participation is contiguous with private roles and consonant with conservative projects centered on tradition and community. Parties deploying NCM, by contrast, direct women toward more confrontational and visible venues (protests, demonstrations, rights-based campaigns) where norm deviance is more salient and reputational costs correspondingly higher. Frames thus embed mobilization within a party's broader ideological project and organizational structure.

This embedding constrains parties from seamlessly switching frames. Pre-existing social cleavages, ideological commitments, brands, organizational affiliations, and coalition partners impose internal and external constraints (Druckman 2001). Internally, parties risk coalitional backlash and activist demobilization. Externally, they risk voter skepticism and credibility erosion when appeals appear opportunistic rather than ideologically rooted.[5]

Religiously conservative parties are well-positioned to employ NAM as they possess prior ideological and organizational repertoires from which such frames naturally emerge. Across contexts—Christian Democratic parties rooted in confessional organizations to Islamic and Hindu nationalist parties embedded in volunteer and service networks—grassroots mobilization has historically been routed through moral duty, community care, discipline, and spiritual obligation (Kalyvas 1996; Mainwaring and Scully 2003; Wickham 2002; Thachil 2014). This foundation shapes rhetoric, recruitment, and socialization as activists are drawn from service organizations and religious networks, already motivated by normatively-coded collective obligation frames. Even when these parties pursue distributive strategies beyond core constituencies, outreach is mediated by organizational affiliates, allowing parties to maintain ideological coherence (Thachil 2014; Brooke 2019).

[5] The UK Conservatives' "Vote Blue, Go Green" repositioning was widely read as a modernization tactic, provoking accusations of opportunistic greenwashing and intra-party backlash. Similarly, the Indian National Congress (INC)'s religious signaling before the 2019 national election was interpreted as strategic "soft *Hindutva*" emerging from opportunism rather than conviction.

This ideological and organizational inheritance means that norm-abiding frames need not originate specifically for gendered mobilization. Rather, they are differentially effective when they align with women's traditional roles, and alternative channels of participation are constrained. This also defines the theory's scope. Where patriarchal norms make women's public engagement costly, NAM provides a socially legible pathway into participation. Where parties possess grassroots organizational infrastructure, they can institutionally incorporate women. NAM is therefore a societally and organizationally contingent theory of women's partisan mobilization.

These structural conditions explain when NAM is available, but what are the behavioral pathways through which it works? The first is motivational: norm-abiding frames align political action with valued identities and familiar social roles centering on the family such as being a good homemaker, caregiver, or embodying family honor. Because these identities cohere with patriarchal ideals of femininity, they reduce the cognitive dissonance and affective resistance that politics, otherwise seen as transgressive, might generate. The second pathway is through justification: NAM provides a norm-consistent rationale that reduces social and reputational penalties by making participation appear appropriate to gatekeepers. Here, women's participation depends less on their own preferences than on gatekeeper acquiescence.

Both routes predict greater participation under NAM than NCM, making it difficult to distinguish if women avoid norm-challenging participation out of attitudinal aversion (the motivation route) or anticipated social sanction (the gatekeeping/justification route). Visibility, however, allows us to partially adjudicate between them. Transgressive actions are more salient when observable, so if NAM works primarily through gatekeeper assent, women's participation should be highly sensitive to visibility (Paler et al. 2018; Kuran 1997; Mutz 2002; Gerber et al. 2008; Dellavigna et al. 2017; Bursztyn et al. 2021). If motivation dominates instead, visibility should matter less, since identity alignment operates regardless of who is watching. Indeed, visibility may even modestly increase participation under NAM by allowing women to publicly signal virtue, duty, or moral respectability.

Taken together, the theory generates the following observable implications: at the party level, religiously conservative parties should employ NAM more than liberal and secular parties. At the individual level, women should prefer NAM to NCM. Gatekeepers should exhibit the same directional preference for women's engagement. If the motivational pathway is robust, NAM should be relatively insensitive to observability. However, if justification is important, men's opinions outweigh women's participation preferences, and NAM's advantage over NCM should be greatest when publicly observable.

3 Norm-abiding mobilization in Hindu Nationalism

In India, the BJP reconciles politics as norm-abiding by framing it as *seva*, a prescriptive norm of selfless service that renders public action continuous with women's private roles. Within the home, *seva* operates as a hierarchical norm of affective caregiving, work that is not prescriptively gendered, but disproportionately performed by women (Lamb 2000; Cohen 2000; Kowalski 2022).[6] An aptitude for service (*seva bhāv*) is accordingly treated as an informal gauge of women's character, making *seva* descriptively feminized in practice even where it may not be formally prescribed as such.

Publicly, *seva* functions as a normative ideal of political engagement that exceeds prevailing political science treatments of constituency service (Fenno 1978; Bussell 2019) and non-state welfare provision (Chidambaram 2012; Thachil 2014; Cammett 2014; Brooke 2019). It encompasses a thicker repertoire of relational practices and dispositions—co-presence, empathy, humility, and responsiveness—through which citizens evaluate and legitimate political authority. Women activists routinely positioned themselves as embedded helpers rather than ambitious politicians, drawing authority from care rather than overt power-seeking (Sen 2007; Bedi 2016; Jakimow 2019). *Seva* therefore validates women's domestic roles and legitimizes public action, facilitating and justifying political entry.

The BJP's deployment of *seva* did not originate as a gender-targeted strategy. *Seva* originally denoted a personal relationship of devotion and service toward a deity or spiritual preceptor (*guru*), a religious register coding service as self-cultivation through humility and self-effacement. Its politicization emerged in colonial-era Hindu revivalist movements that attributed India's subjugation to caste-based and sectarian fragmentation. In response, both secular reformers and religious revivalists reinterpreted *seva* as a vehicle for nation-building (Beckerlegge 2000; Watt 2005). This positioned *seva* as a tool for social cohesion, linking elites to the marginalized through moral obligations for elite-driven upliftment (Patel 2010; Srivatsan 2014). Crucially, this form of service was broad-based and decentralized, allowing participation through labor, cash, and in-kind contributions. It thereby created channels through which previously excluded

[6] Central Statistical Organization (2019)'s time-use survey shows women spend 10 times more than men on unpaid caregiving and domestic work portrayed as *seva* in qualitative interviews.

groups, especially women, could enter public life, as women's presumed aptitude for care made *seva* a socially permissible pathway for public engagement, one exploited by Gandhi to largely inclusive ends for India's freedom movement (Watt 2005; Forbes 1988; Kumar 1997; Kishwar 1986).

These revivalist efforts laid the groundwork for India's Hindu nationalist movement, now led by the RSS. Established in 1925 and banned after Gandhi's assassination, the RSS rebuilt public legitimacy through grassroots service before eventually founding a political party. The RSS continues to foreground *seva* as the face of its ideological project, organizing disaster-relief and welfare camps, cultural gatherings, and quotidian branch meetings and neighborhood-level service activities that function as political socialization and community outreach venues (Bhattacharjee 2019; Sagar 2020). As its political arm, the BJP inherits this infrastructure and deploys it electorally, infusing religious idioms with a communitarian ethos communicated through the discursive use and grassroots practice of *seva*.

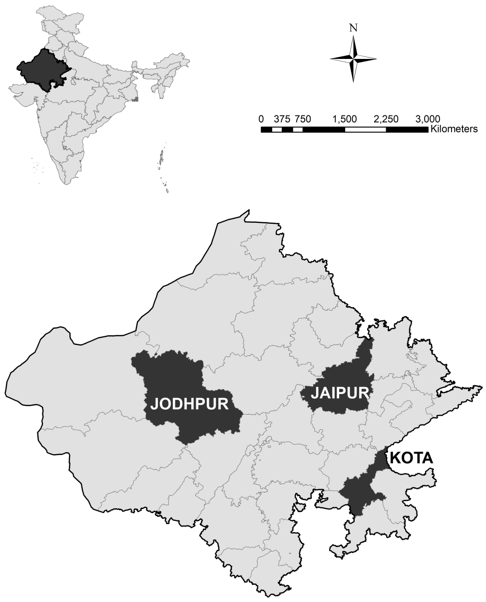
Within this ideological universe, *Hindutva* considers the heteronormative family as the nation's foundational unit, prescribing complementary roles to men and women (Williams 2023). Women are cast as the community's biological and cultural reproducers (Bacchetta and Power 2002), charged with transmitting discipline, moral values, and communitarian obligation to the next generation, a project the RSS frames as central to Hindu nation-building (Alder 2018). This family-nation metonymy extends domestic norms into public life, shaping how women are expected to engage politics and civil society (Menon 2010). Analogous to ideals of Republican motherhood, it does not proscribe participation provided it can be narrated as an extension of domestic duty rather than as autonomous political ambition (Dyahadroy 2009).

Seen through the lens of NAM, the BJP's distinctive contribution is to translate this movement repertoire into partisan practice that women can use to enter political spaces. Party-linked service arenas—welfare drives, cultural gatherings, neighborhood problem-solving, and everyday mediation with the state—create organizational spaces in which women accumulate legitimacy and relational capital while avoiding social costs associated with transgressive politics. When women do contest elections, campaign, or enter more confrontational arenas, the *seva* idiom works to domesticate those actions by embedding them in narratives of duty, sacrifice, and communal protection. *Seva* therefore reconciles women's political participation with patriarchal expectations by channeling engagement toward service, care, and communal duty in ways that make women's political presence legitimate, organizationally durable, and non-threatening to domestic and party gatekeepers.

4 Research Context: Rajasthan as a Prism for Patriarchy

I situate this research in Rajasthan, India's largest state by land area. Within Rajasthan, I selected three districts—Jaipur, Jodhpur, and Kota—for in-depth fieldwork. Encompassing both rural and urban areas, these districts account for nearly 13.4 million people. They were chosen purposively for geographic and cultural diversity and correspond to distinct administrative regions (*prants*) within the RSS.

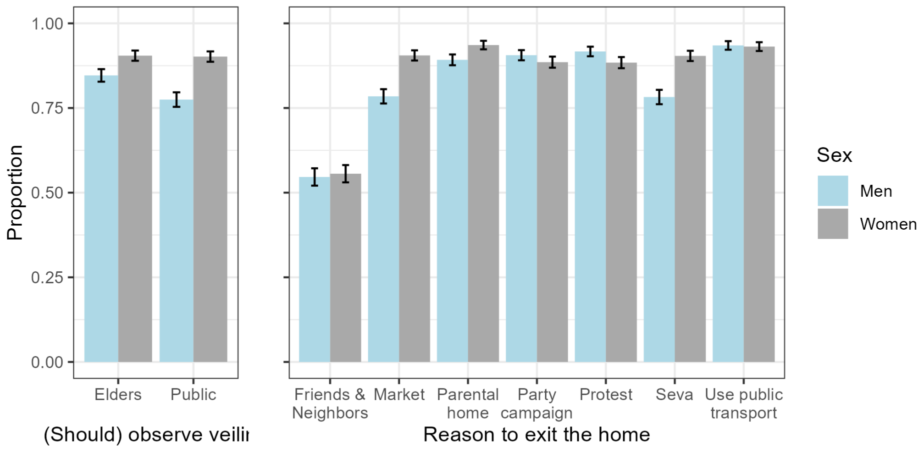
Figure 1: Study districts



Rajasthan reflects the broader gender norms of northern, western, and central India, where women's mobility is constrained by patriarchal expectations. Nearly 90% of women in my survey observe veiling, and a majority require permission from elders to leave home (Figure 2). Pertinently, nearly 88% said they needed permission to attend party campaigns. Men expressed similar expectations, that women should seek permission, though they were slightly less exacting if it was for social service activities.

At the same time, Rajasthan is not an outlier in electoral engagement. Women's turnout rose from 47.5% in 1971 to 65.5% in 2019, narrowing the gender gap from 9.2 to 1.5 percentage points (Figure A.2). Yet, this masks persistent disparities in active engagement. Women remain 21–28 percentage points less likely than men to campaign, attend rallies, or mobilize others (Table C.3). Non-electoral participation is also limited: just 3–5% report involvement in protests or secular service. However, religious service engagement is markedly higher at 54%, indicating an entry point for religiously conservative parties.

Figure 2: Constraints on women's mobility



Note: This shows the share of women who veil or seek permission to enter public spaces, and the share of men who believe women should veil or require permission. Error bars correspond to 95% CIs. Based on author-conducted survey.

Rajasthan's competitive two-party system further strengthens its value as a research site. Since 1990, the BJP and the Indian National Congress (INC) have alternated in power, maintaining parity in electoral and organizational strength. The INC's left-of-center and secular stance provides an ideological contrast to the BJP's right-wing Hindu nationalist position. My fieldwork (December 2018—January 2022) intersected national, state, and local elections, offering multiple windows to observe party mobilization during and between elections. During this period, the INC governed Rajasthan and the BJP governed nationally.

5 Politics as Service: How the BJP uses Norm-abiding Mobilization

I begin with a multi-method comparison of BJP and INC mobilization. The qualitative component draws on three years of fieldwork including participant observation, in=depth interviews, and focus groups with 132 individuals including party activists, RSS affiliates, voters, and key informants.[7] I identified observation opportunities by tracking parties' and activists' social media accounts, regularly visiting party offices, and maintaining conversations with local informants and activists.

Interviews were designed to trace how women negotiated their transition from private to political spheres, and how they mobilized hitherto inactive women. Target respondents thus ranged from experienced mobilizers to event attendees without party roles. Because this popu-

[7] Table C.1 summarizes organizational affiliations; several activists had multiple affiliations.

lation is not listed, I used snowball sampling beginning with national- and state-level elites. This allowed access to local activists, some of whom were unwilling to speak without elite reference. To reduce the risk of over-representing elite-linked activists, I supplemented this with bottom-up node diversification, identifying local activists through official communications, social media, posters, hoardings, and local informants, especially journalists. I also attended public—and when permitted, closed-door—party events, conducting interviews and focus groups during or after them. This helped reach less-visible participants, including those who did not view their participation as political or partisan.

Next, I triangulate this with quantitative data on party rhetoric and grassroots organizing. To test variation in rhetoric, I scraped tweets from BJP and INC women's wings from December 2018 till March 2022, and coded mentions of norm-abiding and norm-challenging frames. To examine if grassroots organizing reflects elite messaging, I surveyed 128 women party activists (74 BJP, 54 INC) about everyday mobilization.[8] Together these test the hypotheses in Table 4.

Table 1: Organizational hypotheses and data sources

Hypothesis	Data source
H1: The BJP will use *seva* more than the INC in its political communication	Women's wing + wing president tweets
H2: BJP activists are more likely than INC activists to organize or participate in *seva*-based events	Party activists' survey

5.1 *Communicating Norm-Abiding Mobilization*

As a standard of conduct core to Hindu nationalism, *seva* enables the BJP to frame politics through normatively held beliefs of collective obligation. Rather than presenting itself as an office-seeking party, the BJP casts itself as a service organization mediating between state and society. Although most visibly performed by party elites, especially Modi, this ethic has grassroots resonance as a common-sense account of political work. As one respondent asked, "What is politics if not *samaj seva*?"[9] Modi's own performances include sweeping streets, collecting garbage, and washing the feet of Dalit sanitation workers—acts associated with lower-caste labor and ritual impurity—thereby recoding political authority as humility, proximity, and selfless service. His self-description of "Prime Servant" (*Pradhan Sevak*) rather than Prime Minister, invocation of *seva* in 80 (of 130) monthly addresses (Figure B.3), and the BJP's annual obser-

[8]The survey was curtailed by the third Covid-19 wave and covers Jaipur and Kota, but not Jodhpur. Qualitative data collection covers all districts.

[9]Kota district, July 2021.

vance of *Seva Saptah* (Service Week) around his birth anniversary, further anchor *seva* to his political persona. Campaigns like *Seva hi Sangathan* (Organization is Service) and *Seva aur Samarpan Abhiyan* (Service and Dedication Mission) institutionalize this ethic, while the BJP's Namo app gamifies grassroots engagement through "*Seva* scores" and "*Seva* Star" badges. This convergence of leadership performance, party discourse, and organizational outreach led then BJP President JP Nadda to claim the BJP was a social service organization interfacing between state and society (Hindustan Times 2021).

By contrast, the INC's women's wing, the All India Mahila Congress (AIMC) more often used assertive right-based language reflected in its motto, "Your right is our fight." This norm-challenging orientation aligns with INC's liberal repertoire of bottom-up claim-making and welfare entitlements (Jayal 2013; Harriss 2011). At a Manifesto Committee meeting, AIMC proposed separating the existing Ministry for Women and Child Development into separate portfolios for gender justice and child development.[10] Other proposals focused on women's outside options including reserving government and private-sector jobs, wage parity, and legal aid. The BJP's women's wing, the Mahila Morcha (BJPMM), advanced no comparable policy proposals to the best of my knowledge. Instead, the BJP's manifesto, including its provisions for women, was drafted centrally, ostensibly with input from public crowdsourcing.[11]

Consistent with this norm-challenging orientation, AIMC members more often described their participation through protests and public claim-making, highlighting activism around women's safety, rising prices, and unemployment. INC women also invoked *seva*, but less frequently than BJP women and was less likely to function as a dominant moral justification for political participation. AIMC elites treated *seva* pragmatically, and at times skeptically with one leader dismissing it as a "gimmick,"[12] and another alleging potential insincerity:

> If women tell you they entered politics to do social service, this is bullshit! You will see that many women talk of *seva*. This is made-up... All women constantly angle for party tickets, be it for councilor, or block, district or MLA.[13]

These qualitative differences suggest divergent mobilization modes, though interviews likely over-represent active and organizationally embedded women. But because mobilization is driven by these actors, the interviews capture an organizationally important stratum, even if not representative of all women party workers. Still, without modeling selection into interviews, it is

[10] Participant observation, February 2019.
[11] Interview with BJPMM official, New Delhi, February 2019.
[12] Interview in New Delhi, February 2020.
[13] Interview in Jaipur, September 2019.

difficult to know whether these patterns reflect broader communication and organization trends.

To address this, I undertake at-scale computational text analysis of tweets issued by the two parties between December 2018—June 2022. During this period, the INC governed Rajasthan and arguably had less structural reason to deploy NCM. Handle selection reflected the official communication apparatus of each party's women's wing, i.e., organizational accounts and serving presidents. I code presence of NAM (*seva*) and NCM (protests, demonstrations, and related terms) keywords within tweets.

Table 2: Prevalence of NAM and NCM keywords on Twitter (X)

	All handles			Women's wing - Organization			Women's wing - President		
	Pooled	Rajasthan	India	Pooled	Rajasthan	India	Pooled	Rajasthan	India
Panel A: Seva									
BJP	0.027***	0.026***	0.029***	0.035***	0.024***	0.039***	0.023***	0.030***	0.015***
	(0.001)	(0.002)	(0.002)	(0.002)	(0.003)	(0.002)	(0.002)	(0.004)	(0.003)
	[<0.01]	[<0.01]	[<0.01]	[<0.01]	[<0.01]	[<0.01]	[<0.01]	[<0.01]	[<0.01]
	{<0.01}	{<0.01}	{<0.01}						
Control mean	0.022	0.020	0.022	0.022	0.021	0.023	0.020	0.016	0.021
Panel B: Protest									
BJP	-0.035***	-0.018***	-0.046***	-0.035***	-0.022***	-0.043***	-0.030***	-0.026***	-0.040***
	(0.001)	(0.002)	(0.002)	(0.002)	(0.003)	(0.003)	(0.002)	(0.004)	(0.003)
	[<0.01]	[<0.01]	[<0.01]	[<0.01]	[<0.01]	[<0.01]	[<0.01]	[<0.01]	[<0.01]
	{<0.01}	{<0.01}	{<0.01}						
Control mean	0.053	0.040	0.060	0.054	0.038	0.064	0.047	0.049	0.047
Panel C: Seva-Protest									
BJP	0.062***	0.044***	0.075***	0.069***	0.046***	0.082***	0.053***	0.056***	0.056***
	(0.002)	(0.003)	(0.003)	(0.003)	(0.004)	(0.003)	(0.003)	(0.006)	(0.004)
	[<0.01]	[<0.01]	[<0.01]	[<0.01]	[<0.01]	[<0.01]	[<0.01]	[<0.01]	[<0.01]
	{<0.01}	{<0.01}	{<0.01}						
Control mean	-0.031	-0.020	-0.038	-0.032	-0.017	-0.041	-0.028	-0.033	-0.025
N	81,409	34,389	47,020	51,637	18,050	33,587	29,772	16,339	13,433

Note: Presence of norm-abiding and norm-challenging frames on Twitter based on regex searches for *seva* and protest-related terms and synonyms. Estimates from bivariate OLS regressions; control means are INC means. SEs in parentheses, uncorrected p-values in square brackets, Benjamini-Hochberg adjusted p-values in braces for preregistered specifications. Stars based on BH-adjusted p-values for preregistered All-handles specifications and uncorrected p-values otherwise. $^{***}p < 0.01$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{*}p < 0.10$.

Findings align with qualitative evidence. 4.6% of Rajasthan-BJPMM tweets mention *seva* (Table 2), a non-trivial share relative to other common terms ("Modi" appears in 17.8%, "Covid" in 7.6%, "Hindu" in less than 1%). In contrast, only 2% of AIMC-Rajasthan tweets mention *seva*. Instead, 4% of AIMC tweets reference norm-challenging repertoires, 1.8 percentage points more than the BJPMM. Panel C shows BJP's discursive communication tilting towards *seva*, whereas the AIMC's communication is more evenly distributed. Robustness checks disaggregating presidents' and organizational accounts yield similar results. These differences are amplified in central-level communication, where the INC's opposition status increases contentious appeals. By contrast, the BJP's continued emphasis on *seva* suggests that NAM is not a regional artifact, but part of a broader partisan repertoire.

5.2 *Organizing Norm-Abiding Mobilization*

These discursive differences map on to grassroots organizing. The Hindu nationalist movement historically opposed incorporating women, with male leaders blocking proposals for a women's wing (Williams 2023). The BJPMM's creation in 1980 created a segregated space within the party, but the wing remained dormant till the mid-1980s and participation continued to be regulated by gatekeepers.[14] In response, women activists structured outreach around religious festivals when women's public mobility was easier to justify.

Contemporary BJP outreach mirrors these strategies. Ahead of the 2024 national election, the BJP launched *Pravaas*, combining voter outreach with religiously-coded service activities like *gauseva* (cow-feeding), temple cleaning, and devotional gatherings. Everyday initiatives included blood donation and medical camps, religious storytelling (*katha*), choirs (*bhajan mandalis*), school-uniform and winter-clothing distribution, festival celebrations in slums, and moral education programs. Allied right-wing organizations reinforced this through cultural programming like a public lecture series titled "Women: From Self to Society," promoting women's community engagement through *seva*.[15] The AIMC instead emphasized norm-challenging programming through *Hamara Haq* (Our Rights) focusing on legal aid, rights education, and leadership development.[16]

To quantify these differences, I surveyed 128 women activists about their grassroots engagement in the preceding three months.[17] Average levels of activism were similar (19 for BJP, 17.2 for INC), but BJP respondents reported a higher share of NAM. As Table 3 shows, 50.7% of events were self-characterized as *seva*-oriented, 13.5 percentage points more than the INC. This contrast was also legible to citizens. In a primary survey of 2,914 respondents (details in Section 6), 44% associated *seva* with the BJP, compared to 27% with the INC.

6 Is Norm-Abiding Mobilization Effective?

The preceding section established partisan differences in the supply-side of NAM. I now examine demand-side preferences using original data from a paired-respondent survey of 1,457 households. In each household, one woman and one man were interviewed by an enumerator of the same

[14]Interview with Mohini Garg, BJPMM founding member, New Delhi, January 2019.
[15]Participant observation in Delhi and Kota, 2019.
[16]Interviews and participant observation in New Delhi, February–March 2019.
[17]Respondents were asked to count the total number of public events organized by their party, or a party member, and then to count the number of service events, protests, and others.

Table 3: Grassroots event-classification by party activists

	Seva			Protest			Seva-Protest		
	BJP	INC	Difference	BJP	INC	Difference	BJP	INC	Difference
	0.507	0.372	0.135*** (0.042) [<0.01] {<0.01}	0.387	0.596	-0.209*** (0.046) [<0.01] {<0.01}	0.120	-0.224	0.344*** (0.082) [<0.01] {<0.01}
N	74	54	128	74	54	128	74	54	128

Note: Share of public events in prior three months classified by activists as norm-abiding or norm-challenging. SEs are in parentheses, uncorrected p-values in square brackets, and Benjamini-Hochberg adjusted p-values in braces. BH correction is applied across the three outcome tests. Stars reflect BH-adjusted p-values. ***$p < 0.01$, **$p < 0.05$, *$p < 0.10$.

sex. Women were selected using a Kish grid, while men were identified as likely gatekeepers based on relationship to the woman respondent or age, producing a gatekeeper match in 86% of households. Interviews were conducted privately and simultaneously to minimize external influence to the extent possible. Experimental treatments were embedded in two designs (a conjoint experiment and a political communication experiment) that randomly exposed respondents to norm-abiding or -challenging appeals.

6.1 *Experimental Designs*

1. Conjoint experiment: Conventional conjoint designs ask participants to choose between two profiles featuring different attributes. In a qualitatively-informed adaptation, I used this design to simulate candidate-led mobilization. Respondents evaluated two hypothetical candidates seeking party nominations, with 6 randomly varying attributes selected for theoretical relevance and fieldwork resonance: (1) candidate sex, (2) party, (3) co-ethnicity,[18] and (4) event frame.[19] I then vary norm perceptions by randomizing (5) interest levels among other women in the community, and (6) number of men assenting to women's attendance.[20] Respondents then rated each profile. Women chose their preferred profile, while men—as gatekeepers—chose the profile they preferred *for the paired woman respondent.* Based on pilots, each respondent completed two choice tasks to minimize fatigue and straightlining.

The key attribute of interest is the event frame, estimating which yields the Average Marginal Component Effect (AMCE) of norm-abiding and -challenging framing compared to the reference

[18] The original design uses caste categories (see Appendix D). I recode this to co-ethnic vs. non-co-ethnic for analysis. Results are robust to choice of design (Table G.2).

[19] Consistent with the theory, *seva* and protests are norm-abiding and -challenging frames respectively. A public meeting serves as an intermediate frame and is the reference category.

[20] See Figure 3 and Appendix D.

Figure 3: Conjoint experiment prompt

Consider this: there is an upcoming election, and two candidates are trying to get an election ticket. They are planning to organize an event near your neighborhood, where they will invite women, including [you/name of female respondent] to attend. I will now tell you a little bit about these candidates and the program.
This is the [first/second] candidate: [He/she] is a [man/woman] and a member of [jati], which is a part of the [caste] community. [He/she] wants to get a ticket from [BJP/INC]. [He/she] is planning to organize a [public meeting/*seva* program/peaceful protest] to work towards and raise awareness for the development of this area. In your neighborhood [Few/many] women have expressed an interest in attending but/and [few/many] men are willing to let women attend.

Outcome Questions:

1. Unfortunately, both events will be held at the same time, so people can only attend one of them. If [you/name of woman respondent] had to attend one of these events (and she asked you), which one would you like (her) to attend?
2. On a scale of 1–10, how much did you like: (a) the first profile, (b) the second profile?
3. *[For women respondents only]* Now if your family had a say in where you should go, which one would they choose for you?
4. *[After the last task only]* Why did you choose this profile?

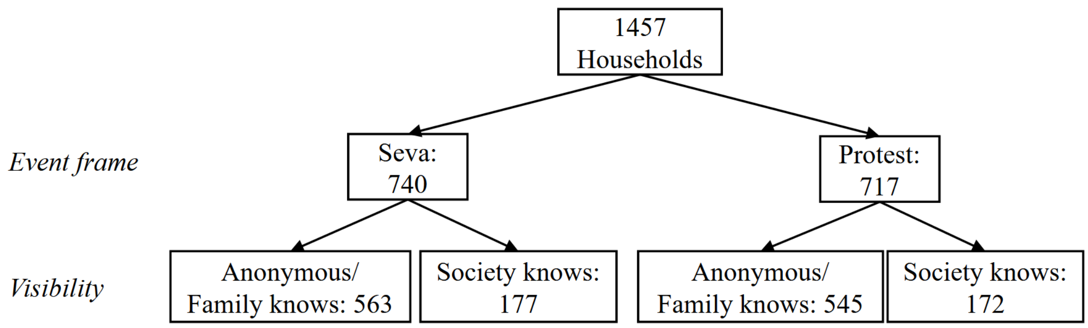
group. Per Hainmueller et al. (2014), I estimate this through an OLS regression:

$$y_{ijk} = \beta_0 + \beta_1 sex_{ijk} + \beta_2 coethnic_{ijk} + \beta_3 party_{ijk} + \beta_4 frame_{ijk} \\ + \beta_5 women's\ interest_{ijk} + \beta_6 men's\ acquiescence_{ijk} + \gamma_i + \epsilon_{ijk} \quad (1)$$

Here, y_{ijk} is a rating or choice by respondent i for profile k in task j, where $j, k \in \{1, 2\}$. γ_i denotes individual fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the respondent-level.

2. Political communication experiment: A potential limitation of the conjoint experiment is that forced-choice designs identify relative preferences, rather than absolute participation levels of interest to parties. To address this, I designed a two-stage political communication experiment (Figure 4). First, respondents were told about potential outreach events planned by representatives, randomly assigned as norm-abiding or -challenging, and asked to rate the event and estimate neighborhood participation. Second, respondents were asked whether they wished to exercise voice by transmitting these opinions to their representative under randomly assigned visibility conditions: complete anonymity (50%), partial visibility (known to family, 25%), or complete visibility (known to family, community, and representative, 25%). This produced a 2×3 factorial design, but complete anonymity proved difficult to ensure in practice. Enumerators secured privacy from men, but could not always isolate female respondents from other women in the household, particularly in small dwellings or during domestic chores. To maximize power, I pool the first two conditions and compare them to the complete visibility group in the main analysis. I adjust all estimates for survey privacy based on enumerators' indication of external observation. To test robustness, I compare effect sizes with and without adjusting for survey privacy (Table H.2), and after dropping the partial visibility group (Table H.3). Results show minimal substantive differences.

Figure 4: Political communication experiment



As you know, [Sarpanch / Councilor] elections were held in the last 1-2 years. But because of COVID, many new leaders have not been able to meet with voters. Some of them are interested in interacting with voters [...] start working for the development of this [village/ward]. They will do this through a [*seva* event/peaceful protest]. The event will start with an address by your leader. After that, [there will be a march where we will shout slogans/we will do *seva* and a *padyatra*] and get other people in the area to join. This will help raise awareness about how the party is working to make people's lives better and show people how they can contribute to improve their community.
Outcome questions 1: (a) Can you rate this event on a scale of 1–10?; (b) If I were to ask 10 men in your *mohalla* about this, how many of them do you think would take part?; (c) If I were to ask 10 women in your *mohalla* about this, how many of them do you think would take part?
Outcome question 2: Thank you for sharing your opinion. To help your representative decide, we would like to tell them what people in their constituency think. Are you willing to send this opinion to your representative? If you choose to do so, [we will not disclose your decision or your name to anyone inside or outside the household, including the other respondent and your representative / we will not disclose your name to anyone outside the household but your family will know / we will publish your name in a newspaper a few days after we complete this survey, and also share your name with your representative. So, people in your family, members of your community and your representative will come to know that you sent your opinion]. So, would you like to send your opinion?

The outcome in this experiment, exercising political voice, differs from physical attendance in the conjoint, but this distinction is necessary to adjudicate between mechanisms. As hypothesized, greater support for NAM may stem from attitudinal aversion to NCM or anticipated social sanction for norm violation, but it may also reflect the instrumental or expressive benefits of NAM. Distinguishing these requires experimentally varying participation visibility. This is impossible in the conjoint as physical attendance is axiomatically public and known to family and community. I therefore use the related outcome of exercising voice as its visibility can be experimentally manipulated.[21]

I evaluate the effectiveness of framing and visibility as an average treatment effect calculated through a difference-of-means estimated through a covariate-adjusted OLS regression $y_i = \beta_0 + \beta_1 x_i + \gamma_i + \varepsilon_i$. Here, y is a binary variable that indicates whether the i^{th} respondent chose to exercise voice about the proposed event, x represents treatment assignment, and γ represents a vector of pre-specified covariates, including age, education, wealth i.e. asset ownership, caste, religion, religiosity, political knowledge, and history of political engagement. Table 4 summarizes the hypotheses and corresponding research designs.

Table 4: Pre-registered behavioral hypotheses and designs

Hypothesis	Conjoint expt.	Political comm. expt.
Participation		
H3: Women prefer norm-abiding (to intermediate) to norm-challenging frames	✓	✓
Gatekeepers		
H4: Men prefer norm-abiding (to intermediate) to norm-challenging frames *for women*	✓	×
H5: Women's participation is more sensitive to men's opinions than other women	✓	×
Visibility mechanisms		
H6*: If NAM operates through motivation, its effect should be insensitive to public visibility.	×	✓
H7*: If NAM operates through justification, its advantage over NCM should increase under public visibility.	×	✓

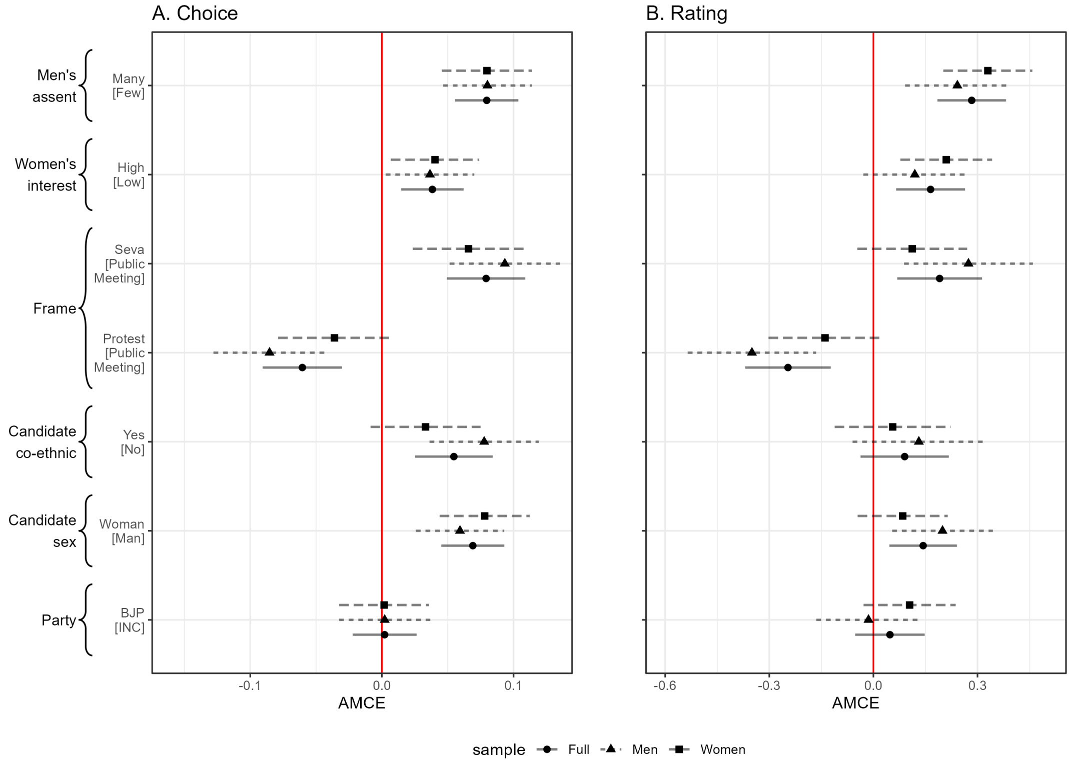
* *Exploratory (non-pre-registered) hypotheses*

Results

We begin with the conjoint experiment. If H3 holds, women should prefer *seva*-framed profiles over the reference group, and both over protests. Figure 5 (Table G.1) presents results from the pre-specified conjoint analysis. Relative to the reference category, women are 6.6 percentage points more inclined to choose norm-abiding profiles ($p_{BH} < 0.01$) and 3.6 percentage points less likely to choose norm-challenging ones (albeit $p_{BH} = 0.139$). Together, this constitutes a

[21] Conceptually, voice and physical attendance are alternative operationalizations of the same construct, women's entry into the public sphere. Recent scholarship shows voice is a costly form of women's participation in South Asia and beyond (Khan 2021; Coffé and Bolzendahl 2010; Grossman et al. 2014). Feminist scholarship further argues that the very act of articulating voice, regardless of content, is itself costly when women's public role is circumscribed (Beard 2014). Furthermore, using related operationalizations of the same construct strengthens inference through convergent validity (Campbell et al. 2001) and "y-validity" of causal designs (Egami and Hartman 2023).

Figure 5: Conjoint experiment results



Note: This shows the AMCE for all attribute-levels, relative to the one in brackets based on estimating Equation 1. Error bars indicate 95% CIs. Corresponding data in Table G.1.

difference of 10.2 percentage points between NAM and NCM. Coefficient signs are similar for the intensive margin: women's rate norm-challenging profiles lower by 0.139 points ($p_{BH} < 0.1$), and norm-abiding frames higher by 0.112 points (but $p_{BH} > 0.1$), an aggregate swing of 0.251 points.

Findings from the political communication experiment concur (Table 5). Pooling across visibility conditions, women's voice rises by 6.1 percentage points in the norm-abiding relative to the norm-challenging condition ($p_{BH} < 0.01$). Men's communication is unaffected by frame. This is consistent with the expectation that *seva* frames are differentially effective for women since men's political engagement is not perceived as role-incongruent.

Both experimental results are robust to estimation and specification choices. Additional robustness tests estimate marginal means corrected for swapping bias (Clayton et al. 2023) in the conjoint to find similar results (Figure G.2). Similarly, dropping pre-specified covariates in the political communication experiment does not change results. A specification curve varying covariate sets, fixed effects, and sub-samples confirms that the pre-specified estimates are representative of the broader distribution of plausible specifications (Figure H.1).

Are these results driven by substantively important sub-groups? Disaggregating by religion

Table 5: Effect of framing and visibility on exercising voice

	Women			Men		
	Panel A: Frame					
	Social visibility			Social visibility		
	Pooled	Anon	Visible	Pooled	Anon	Visible
Seva	0.061***	0.036*	0.138***	0.008	-0.001	0.051
	(0.018)	(0.018)	(0.046)	(0.016)	(0.018)	(0.036)
	[<0.01]	[0.047]	[<0.01]	[0.601]	[0.942]	[0.153]
	{<0.01}	{0.095}	{<0.01}	{0.721}	{0.942}	{0.230}
Control mean	0.831	0.873	0.698	0.894	0.905	0.860
N	1,457	1,108	349	1,457	1,107	350
	Panel B: Visibility					
	Frame			Frame		
	Pooled	Seva	Protest	Pooled	Seva	Protest
Visible	-0.126***	-0.072**	-0.187***	-0.024	-0.007	-0.043
	(0.024)	(0.030)	(0.037)	(0.019)	(0.026)	(0.029)
	[<0.01]	[0.016]	[<0.01]	[0.218]	[0.796]	[0.148]
	{<0.01}	{0.033}	{<0.01}	{0.261}	{0.796}	{0.223}
Control mean	0.893	0.911	0.873	0.904	0.904	0.905
N	1,457	740	717	1,457	741	716

Note: Entries show framing and visibility effects on exercising voice from covariate-adjusted regressions with randomization-block fixed effects, including pre-specified covariates and survey privacy. Panel A compares *Seva* to Protest framing; Panel B compares social visibility to anonymity/partial visibility. SEs, clustered by treatment assignment, are in parentheses. Uncorrected p-values in brackets; Benjamini-Hochberg adjusted p-values in braces. BH correction is applied within each panel. Stars reflect BH-adjusted p-values. $^{***}p < 0.01$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{*}p < 0.10$.

is uninformative as over 90% of the sample is Hindu. Turning to caste, we may expect stronger effects for upper-caste women given the elite origins of Hindu nationalism and stronger restrictions to public presence (Chakravarti 1993; Agte and Bernhardt 2023). Aligning with this, the conjoint shows strongest NAM effects for upper-caste women (Figure G.3). But this heterogeneity is muted in the political communication experiment (Figure H.2). Here, the *difference* between NAM and NCM is highest for upper-caste and ST women, suggesting *seva*'s mobilizational reach may extend beyond upper-caste women. Ciotti (2012), for instance, finds Dalit women politicians also invoke *seva* in their political narratives. These effects should however be interpreted with caution as the survey was not designed to detect caste-based heterogeneity reliably and comparisons may be underpowered.

7 How and Why Does Norm-Abiding Mobilization Succeed?

I now turn to the question of how NAM operates, focusing on the two channels of motivation and justification. While these channels operate through distinct players in the causal chain—women and gatekeepers respectively—they are interdependent in practice. Gatekeeper enforcement may deepen norm internalization among women and identity-consistent participation may ease household negotiation.

7.1 *Seva* as Motivation

The motivational channel posits that NAM works by aligning political engagement with women's domestic identities, thereby bridging the private and public spheres. Tracing this mechanism requires evidence sensitive to how women interpret their own involvement. I therefore draw on ethnographically-grounded qualitative evidence from multiple in-depth interview sessions, which are well suited to capturing subjective interpretations of political action (Wedeen 2010; Brady and Collier 2010). Through repeated visits and cumulative conversations lasting 2–5 hours, I find BJP workers did not passively absorb *seva* frames; they actively used them to render political work intelligible within their normative self-understandings. As one councilor explained, "Politics is like what we do at home. Men give money to run the home, but our sacrifice keeps the family together. Similarly, men contest elections, but the organization (*sangathan*) and society (*samaj*) will break without our *seva*."[22]

This familial framing also supported narratives of active self-making, most clearly expressed in a District President's description of her political trajectory:

> I did a lot of social work in college... I was an animal rights activist. I slapped [animal cruelty] cases on many people, but I have stopped this now. After I joined [the BJP] I understood my job is to unite people, not divide them. When I started, I was young, older activists were not welcoming. But they saw my work, they attended my programs, and they saw my way of talking. And slowly I was able to bring people together. You can say I was like a *bahu* (daughter-in-law) who earns her family's respect through *seva*.[23]

Other women's motivational arcs began before formal political entry. A former activist organized service events as a "housewife" before politics gave an institutional channel for this familiar work.[24] For others, *seva* gave a sense of purpose during personal disruption. One of the few Muslim women activists in the BJP recounted turning to politics as a coping mechanism, "I was interested in *seva* since childhood... I joined BJP after my divorce so I could forget the bad parts of my life. I lost myself in others' problems. Three things kept me alive, *dua* (blessings), *dava* (medicines), and *seva*." While a single case warrants caution, the resonance of *seva* across

[22] Interview in Jodhpur, November 2019.
[23] Interview in New Delhi, February 2019.
[24] Interview, Kota, July 2019.

religious lines suggests its mobilizational logic taps into a common ethic of selfless service beyond Hinduism.[25]

Familializing metaphors reinforced these individual narratives. In focus groups, activists described the party as a family that valued them as "sisters" and "mothers."[26] In an election campaign, a woman candidate was introduced as "fortunate to get a chance to do *seva* to both her in-laws [metonym for Ramganjmandi constituency] earlier, and now her parental home [Keshoraipatan constituency]."[27] Social media too reflects this language with the Rajasthan BJPMM using familial terms (mother, wife, aunt, sister, sister-in-law, daughter, and daughter-in-law) in 29.1% of tweets that mentioned women, roughly double the INC (Table B.3).

These accounts show political legitimacy emerging through *seva*-centered self-cultivation with women reinterpreting politics as consistent with a valued self-identity. Simultaneously, *seva*'s interpretive flexibility could, under certain conditions, work in the opposite direction to reframe transgressive action as role-congruent. Illustrating this, a BJPMM activist , addressing a public meeting after a terrorist attack declared, "As mothers, we sacrifice to raise the next generation... the day Modi*ji* gives the order, we will stand on the border with AK-47s. This will be our *seva*."[28] Notwithstanding the obvious rhetorical flourish, armed resistance was folded into maternal service, simultaneously expanding the range of feasible actions women could undertake while preserving normative self-continuity.

The political communication experiment permits an exploratory test of the domestic identity-alignment mechanism. I operationalize women's domestic role identity as the importance they attach to being good homemakers and maintaining their family's social standing as dimensions of their personal identity. If identity alignment operates, norm-abiding frames should resonate more strongly for whom this identity is most salient. Table H.4 shows a positive interaction between *seva* framing and domestic identity ($p < 0.1$), indicating that NAM's advantage grows with domestic role identification.

I also consider two alternative motivational mechanisms for women supporting conservative parties: instrumental and attitudinal. Instrumental accounts explain women's support to benefits from norm-conforming behavior. These may be social, for example improved marriage-market prospects under conservative gender regimes (Blaydes and Linzer 2008), material benefits

[25]Muslim activists preferred using *seva*, rather than the Islamic *khidmat*.
[26]Interviews and focus groups in New Delhi and Jaipur, February-March 2019.
[27]Public meeting, Kota, December 2018.
[28]Participant observation at Jaipur, February 2019.

mediated through parties, or psychological such as social esteem. Attitudinal accounts locate women's support in religiosity (Duverger 1955; Moghadam and Kaftan 2019; Emmenegger and Manow 2014; Shorrocks 2018). If instrumental considerations drive NAM, visibility should amplify norm-abiding engagement since public visibility increases opportunities to signal virtue, gain esteem, or signal support to access party-mediated welfare. Instead, visibility reduces voice even within the norm-abiding group by 7.2 percentage points (Table 5, Panel B), suggesting visibility activates social costs more than benefits. Moreover, welfare receipt is not associated with women's voice (Appendix J), weakening the material incentives account.

Next, if attitudinal conservatism was dominant, women should display a stable internalized aversion to norm-challenging participation regardless of visibility. Yet, under social anonymity, 87.3% women exercise voice under the norm-challenging condition, barely 3 percentage points below men. Such high private participation is difficult to square with internalized conservative attitudes. The results also clarify the role of ideological commitments more generally. The framing effect is present among both BJP and non-BJP identifiers (Figure I.1), ruling out partisan cue-taking. Nor does religiosity account for the effect. While religiosity predicts baseline participation, it does not predict differential sensitivity to *seva* framing (Appendix J).

Taken together, the qualitative and quantitative evidence point to a motivational channel rooted in *seva*'s capacity to align political participation with familiar identities, with women undertaking the interpretive work, and the BJP providing the discursive and organizational infrastructure through which this alignment becomes possible.

7.2 Negotiating gatekeeping: *Seva* as Justification

The second path through which NAM enables women's participation is by easing gatekeepers' acquiescence. The conjoint experiment tests this (H4) directly by examining which profile men prefer *for the paired woman respondent*. Focusing on the event frame attribute, men's choices align with women's in direction but are stronger in magnitude (Figure 5, Table G.1). Relative to the reference category, men are 9.3 percentage points more likely to choose norm-abiding profiles and 8.5 percentage points less likely to choose norm-challenging ones. Crucially, men's aversion to norm-challenging frames is more than 5 percentage points greater than women's own ($p < 0.1$), consistent with gatekeepers being more sensitive to social norms. These findings are robust to alternative estimation methods and swapping bias correction (Figure G.2). However, in contrast to women, men show no caste-based heterogeneity (Figure G.3), suggesting NAM mitigates gatekeeping uniformly across caste categories.

These findings align with qualitative evidence on women activists' routes into politics. Consider first, Kamla, a BJP activist: "I was the first woman in my community to join a party. My father-in-law was very displeased when my husband told him... So, I said it was a way to serve our community."[29] Another activist, Rita's trajectory illustrates the fluid role of *seva* more fully—as a channel to access the public sphere, a conduit for party recruitment, and a lever to obtain familial acquiescence by downplaying personal ambition:

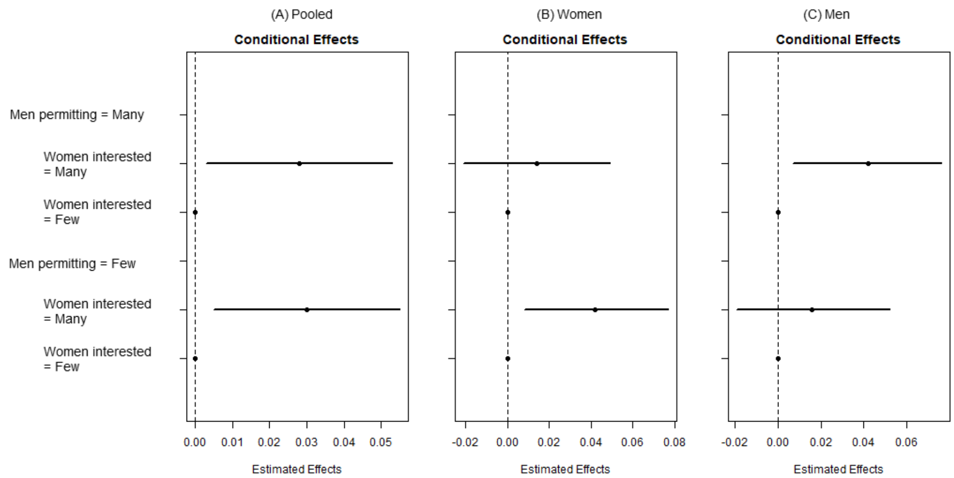
> I was interested in politics, but my in-laws opposed this. But they said, "If you want to do social service that's fine." Then when quotas were implemented, parties needed women. My *seva* had given me an identity, so parties approached me. I knew my family wasn't very interested, so I declined. But a family friend told my husband, "We always complain there are no good people in politics. If she doesn't contest, there will be no change and we will keep complaining." My husband discussed with his parents who saw I had not pressed him to mediate for me, so they thought this might, after all, be the right thing to do.[30]

While Rita's initial restraint reinforced her suitability for politics in her family's eyes, other activists deployed *seva* more strategically. Lekha described framing party events as community service to circumvent resistance, "Women won't come to party events, so, I say we do social service, not politics... First we bring people through religious events and meetings in temples... Once there is a relationship, they start coming to my house and for other programs."[31] Another Durga Vahini (RSS-affiliated women's organization) member and BJP organizer described a related tactic, "Some families are old-fashioned, they don't allow women to go out. Then we hold *seva-satsang* (religious service event) in their house itself. After some time, they feel comfortable [permitting women to go out]." A related variant operated further upstream, through preemptive consent-seeking. An RSS functionary described this, "Before I ask anyone to join, I always speak to her family. I tell them about the kind of work... and how long they might need to spend outside. After the family agrees, I formalize women's entry.[32]

Together, these accounts reveal *seva*'s role as both instrumental and affective, deployed differently depending on whether gatekeepers' objection can be dissolved, circumvented, or foreclosed. Patriarchy thus does not preclude women's engagement *per se*, but *shapes* it by prescribing permissible activities.

[29] Focus group discussion in Jaipur, November 2021.
[30] Interview in March 2019, Jaipur.
[31] Interview, Jaipur, September 2019.
[32] Interview in June 2019, Kota.

Figure 6: AMIE of women's interest, conditional on men's acquiescence



Note: Effect of women's interest at each level of men's acquiescence. Bars indicate 95% CIs.

7.3 Adjudicating between the mechanisms

The preceding discussion shows how NAM can operate as both motivation and justification. Although the experimental designs do not allow me to decompose these, they do permit a more informed assessment of how NAM operates. I begin with the conjoint experiment, which allows me to compare the relative importance of men's acquiescence and women's interest (H5). I find both male and female respondents are 8 percentage points more likely to choose profiles where men's acquiescence is high (Figure 5). However, manipulating perceptions of women's interest changes profile choice by 3.7–4 percentage points, less than half the effect of men's acquiescence. This is not statistically significant for male respondents and does not survive the BH correction for female respondents (Table G.1).

This asymmetry suggests justification may matter more than motivation, but does not eliminate the possibility that strong intrinsic motivation can offset gatekeeping. To assess this, I estimate the Average Marginal Interaction Effect (AMIE) (Egami and Imai 2019). In the pooled sample (Figure 6), women's interest matters regardless of men's permissibility. But upon disaggregating by sex, I find women weigh other women's interest more when men's assent is low (suggesting substitution). Men, however, respond to women's interest only when they simultaneously receive strong signals of assent from *other men* (suggesting complementarity). Thus, if men regulate women's participation, political entry will occur on male gatekeepers' terms, even if women themselves hold divergent preferences.

Visibility provides a final test through the political communication experiment. If NAM works primarily through identity-consistent engagement, visibility should have little effect—or even a mildly positive one (H6). Yet even under NAM, public observability produces a decline in women's willingness to exercise political voice (Table 5, Panel B).

Finally NAM's advantage over NCM increase under public visibility (H7). In the pooled sample in Table 5 Panel B, I find, perhaps strikingly, no gender gap in the social anonymity group (0.893 vs 0.905). But when observable, women's public voice drops by 12.6 percentage points with no concomitant drop for men. This drop is steeper in the norm-challenging (18.7 percentage points, 21.4% from the baseline), compared to the norm-abiding group (7.2 percentage points), consistent with women updating behavior in response to anticipated normative costs that activate under social observation and sanction.

Taken together, both motivation and justification shape participation, but justification is more pertinent at entry, especially when patriarchal norms constrain independent mobility. Motivation nonetheless remains a complementary channel. Qualitative evidence shows identity alignment is a cumulative process built through repeated participation, organizational socialization, and gradual self-revision, with longer time horizons than can be captured by one-shot experiments. Moreover, the two channels are interdependent: stronger identity alignment may ease gatekeeper negotiation by making women's motivations more credible and less threatening to gatekeepers. The experiments administered to a politically inactive population—only 3% female respondents were party members—identify proximate entry conditions while activists' biographies illuminate the longer trajectory through which motivation accumulates, gatekeepers are accommodated, and participation is sustained.

8 Implications for parties

Returning to the broader question motivating this article, the present research design shows how religiously conservative and secular parties differ in the composition of their mobilization strategies, and the implications of this divergence for women's participation. We find the BJP deploys NAM more than the INC; women are more receptive to NAM; and gatekeepers are more willing to acquiesce to NAM. This argument does not require NAM to generate qualitatively distinct responses among BJP partisans. Indeed, both BJP-identifying and non-identifying respondents were directionally aligned in their evaluations (Figure I.1). This may be because framing was the most important attribute shaping choices (Figure G.1), suggesting that *seva* carried sufficient positive valence to transcend partisan attribution. BJP-aligned men do exhibit somewhat stronger preferences for NAM and aversion to NCM than non-BJP men (Figure I.1), but the sample is underpowered to estimate these differences precisely.

Exploratory analysis however does suggest some scope for differential effectiveness. Observationally, BJP-identifying women are more likely to attribute the political gender gap to gatekeeper constraints (Table I.1). On the gatekeeper side, BJP-aligned men are 4.9 percentage points more likely to relax mobility restrictions for women's *seva* (Table I.2), and more likely to base their decisions about women's participation based on framing (Figure G.1). These patterns suggest both the demand for NAM and the returns to deploying them are higher where patriarchal constraints are more binding.

Experimental evidence points in a similar direction. The visibility condition of the political communication experiment, which most closely approximates attending public events, reveals a large baseline gap (Figure I.3). BJP-identifying women report lower willingness to exercise political voice under the norm-challenging frame (0.651 vs 0.744). Yet within this subgroup, NAM reduces the participation deficit by 18.9 percentage points ($p_{BH} < 0.05$), again suggesting NAM is especially effective where the social costs of political participation are highest. These findings are consistent with a two-stage account of BJP expansion: organizational outreach increases women's incorporation into political networks, while *seva* framing activates participation, particularly for those facing higher baseline costs of engagement. At the same time, these analyses are exploratory and non-preregistered, and should therefore be interpreted cautiously. Whether NAM has systematically different effects across the partisan divide remains an important question for future research.

9 Discussion: Parties, Norms, and the Boundaries of Gender Inclusion

This article addressed how religiously conservative parties incorporate women where public political engagement is socially costly. Focusing on the BJP in India, I develop a theory of NAM to explain how parties can expand without diluting ideology or provoking backlash. Triangulating qualitative fieldwork, computational text analysis, observational data, and causal evidence from ethnographically-informed experiments, I show framing can reduce the costs of women's public engagement.

To be sure, NAM should not be construed as the only explanation for the BJP's success. Alternative explanations including attitudinal conservatism, instrumental motivations, structural factors such as organizational outreach or nomination patterns, and behavioral explanations such as misperceived norm corrections may also contribute. The approach of this article is not to treat these as competing frameworks, but as complementary mechanisms. While I have evaluated prominent alternatives here, space constraints preclude an extended discussion of others, which I address in Appendix J.

When is NAM effective, and for which types of parties? NAM is a societally and organizationally contingent theory conditioned by the strength of patriarchal norms and the depth of party organization. On the societal dimension, NAM applies most directly to settings characterized as classic patriarchies (Kandiyoti 1988)—patrilineal, patrilocal household structures in which men's control over women's mobility is institutionalized. These conditions are most prevalent in South Asia, North Africa, and the Muslim Middle East. When patriarchal norms are weak and the costs of women's visible activism correspondingly low, NAM's marginal advantage diminishes, though it need not disappear entirely. Women's entry into Western political life illustrates this, with suffrage movements in the US, Britain, and Latin America grounding their demands not in opposition to prevailing gender roles but in the distinctive moral authority that motherhood and domestic experience conferred on women (Kraditor 1973; Cott 1987). Similarly, women's civic organizing through "municipal housekeeping" and moral reform movements invoked traditional femininity to justify entry into public life before patriarchal gatekeeping weakened (Baker 1984; Skocpol 1995; Rymph 2006).

The second constraint is organizational. NAM is most effective when parties possess the capacity to institutionalize norm-abiding participation within their grassroots apparatus. The BJP is therefore not unique. Turkey's Refah/AKP mobilized women through *imece*, a norm of reciprocal communal labor that channeled activism through neighborhood welfare and religious instruction contiguous with domestic roles (White 2011). Simultaneously, *himaye*, a norm of male patronage and guardianship eased gatekeeper acquiescence by embedding women's participation within vertically organized relations of family protection. Hezbollah expanded women's participation through charity networks and Quranic study circles framed as religious duty (Deeb 2011). The Muslim Brotherhood in Egypt and Jordan similarly routed women's activism through Islamic welfare organizations presented as expressions of religious obligation rather than political engagement (Clark 2004; Wickham 2002).

Can secular parties deploy NAM under patriarchy? Experimental evidence shows positive behavioral responses regardless of party source, indicating a potential opening. Yet two constraints limit this possibility. First, religiously conservative parties may possess stronger brand associations with NAM, creating a first-mover advantage. Second, effective deployment requires consistency between frames, ideology, and organizational practice. The INC illustrates both difficulties. Gandhi's religiosity and moral authority enabled him to deploy forms of NAM that encouraged gatekeepers to acquiesce to women's participation in the freedom movement (Forbes 1988). However, the post-independence Nehruvian turn toward secular-scientific rationalism, subsequent organizational atrophy (Franda 1962; Chhibber 1999), and the Congress Party's more recent association with liberal activism may have weakened its ability to compete on the same terrain within a largely patriarchal society. Whether secular parties can construct functional equivalents to NAM without ideological capitulation remains a question for future research.

Finally, what are the broader implications of NAM? While thorough answers require additional research, this article suggests some possibilities. Women entering politics through norm-congruent pathways gain mobility, associational networks, and civic skills that afford a modicum of agency even within conservative movements (Mahmood 2004; Deeb 2011; Ben Shitrit 2015; Chowdhury 2023). Yet these gains are likely circumscribed if sustained participation depends on gatekeeper acquiescence.

More broadly, these findings shed light on an important emerging puzzle. Participation and inclusion are often assumed to strengthen democracy, but cases of democratic erosion amid rising engagement, particularly in India, belie this. NAM partially helps reconciles this paradox by highlighting that the intensive margin of *how* people participate is as important as the extensive margin of *how many*. Because NAM is not inherently antagonistic to existing power structures, it may crowd out more assertive models of citizenship grounded in individual rights and liberties that underpin resilient democracies.

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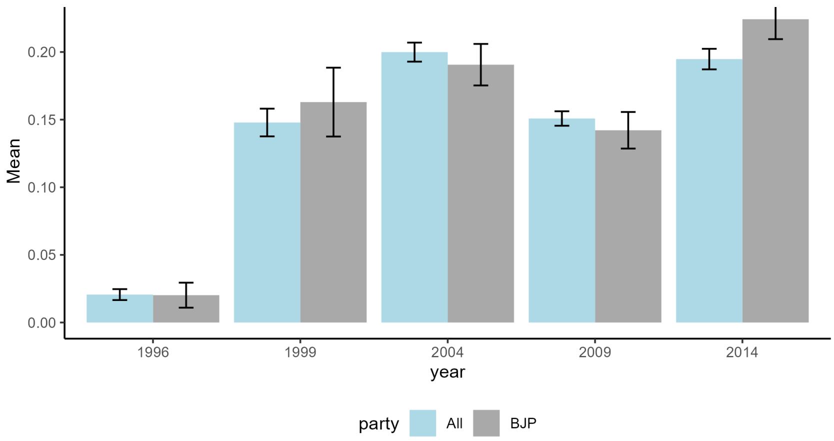
Appendices

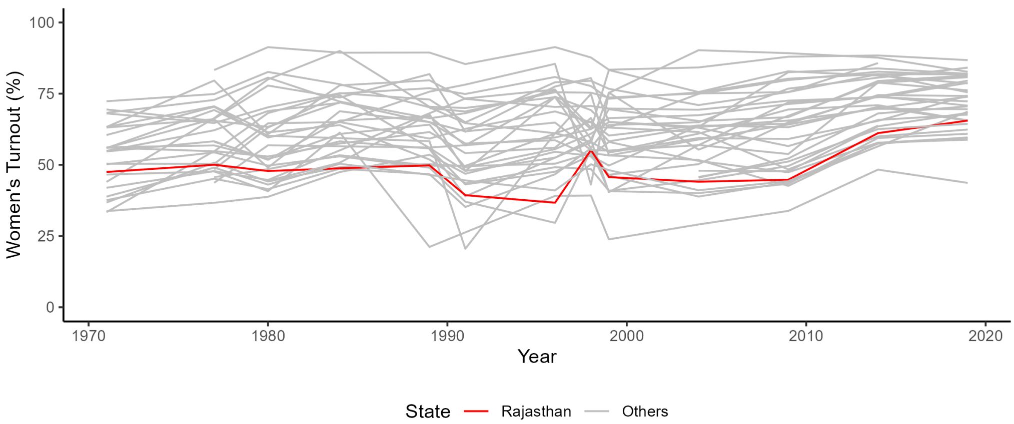
A Overall trends in turnout and public presence

Figure A.1: Increase in women's active participation in national elections



Note: Source: National Election Studies, CSDS Delhi. Bars indicate 95% confidence intervals. The y-axis measures whether women took part in at least one of the following activities: attending rallies and processions, election meetings, conducting door to door canvassing, distributing posters or pamphlets, and collecting donations.

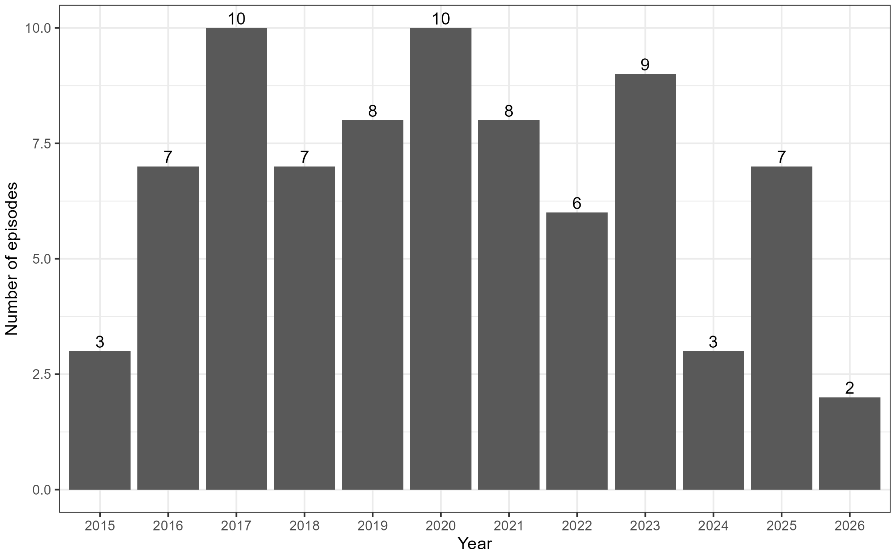
Figure A.2: Turnout in national elections (1971-2019)



Source: Election Commission of India

B Social media analysis

Figure B.3: *Seva* mentions in Narendra Modi's monthly national address



Note: This figure reports the number of monthly *Mann ki Baat* addresses in which Narendra Modi invokes *seva*, through February 2026. In all years prior to 2026, the maximum possible number of episodes is 12, except in 2019 and 2024. In those election years, *Mann ki Baat* was paused during the campaign period, reducing the annual maximum to 9. Episodes are excluded if their only mentions of *seva* refer to bureaucratic services or military awards (*seva* medals).

Table B.1: Account Summary Statistics

Party	Level	Entity	Handle	N	Start date	End date	Followers	Favorite perc.	Retweet perc.
BJP	State	President	AlkaMundra	3727	2020-11-19	2022-02-15	4667	0.25	9.99
BJP	State	President	madhusharmabjp	13994	2020-05-30	2021-08-21	19859	0.00	7.01
BJP	State	Women's Wing	rajmahilamorcha	4692	2019-01-02	2022-02-15	6459	0.00	11.14
BJP	Center	President	VanathiBJP	7977	2019-08-06	2022-02-16	235435	0.15	0.46
BJP	Center	President	VijayaRahatkar	3566	2018-12-19	2020-10-30	44904	0.43	5.24
BJP	Center	Women's Wing	BJPMahilaMorcha	10640	2019-03-01	2022-02-16	45609	0.09	7.14
INC	State	President	RayazRehana	2345	2018-12-19	2022-02-15	7018	0.29	29.32
INC	State	Women's Wing	RajasthanPMC	13358	2019-03-31	2022-02-16	10850	0.03	6.48
INC	Center	President	dnetta	1773	2021-08-17	2022-02-16	38048	0.67	5.23
INC	Center	President	sushmitadevinc	3683	2018-12-10	2021-06-09	276011	0.20	0.66
INC	Center	Women's Wing	MahilaCongress	22947	2019-10-25	2022-02-16	258609	0.07	0.47

Note: This table shows descriptive statistics, engagement, and content details for women's wing and their presidents' handles within the scraping window. Seva and protest columns show the percentage of tweets containing keywords, favorite and retweet columns scale number of users favoriting or retweeting by follower count. Start and end date for women's wing Presidents reflects their tenure or tweet availability.

Table B.2: Associations of seva mentions with women mentions by party (all tweets)

	Prevalence of seva
Women	0.00004
	(0.002)
BJP	0.026***
	(0.001)
Women X BJP	0.007**
	(0.003)
Constant	0.022***
	(0.001)
Observations	88,702

Note: Entries report OLS estimates of the prevalence of *seva* mentions as a function of party, women mentions, and their interaction, across all tweets. SEs in parentheses. *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01.

Table B.3: Women being addressed in familial terms

	Prevalence of keywords in tweets		
	Familial address		
	(1)	(2)	(3)
BJP	0.106***	0.068***	0.160***
	(0.021)	(0.023)	(0.020)
Constant	0.193***	0.198***	0.183***
	(0.006)	(0.006)	(0.001)
Sample	Pooled	Central	Rajasthan
Observations	16,870	10,480	6,390

Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01. This table shows difference in how women are addressed in social media across the BJP and the INC. Familial addresses for women are references to their domestic identities such as mother, mother-in-law, sister, sister-in-law, daughter, daughter-in-law, and aunt. Central refers to national or federal level. Estimates are based on bivariate OLS regressions.

C Sampling and Respondent Selection

C.1 Party activists

Grassroots activists were recruited using a respondent-driven approach. Respondents range from activists without official party positions to current and former booth-level workers, block- or *mandal*-level functionaries, district- and state-level office bearers, and current and former *Sarpanches* and councilors. Table C.1 shows the organizational affiliations of respondents with right-wing affiliations. Table C.2 shows summary statistics.

Table C.1: Main Sangh Parivar organizations

Name of Organization	**Function within the Sangh**
Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS)	Parent Organization, grassroots mobilization
Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)	Political party arm
Rashtra Sevika Samiti	Women's wing of RSS
Vishva Hindu Parishad (VHP)	Cultural affairs and international activities
Matri Shakti	Women's wing of VHP
Bajrang Dal	Youth wing of VHP (for men aged 15-35)
Durga Vahini	Women's wing of Bajrang Dal
Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP)	Students' union
Bharatiya Kisan Sangh	Farmers' union
Seva Bharti	Social service
Muslim Rashtriya Manch	Muslim mobilization

Table C.2: Descriptive statistics by party activists

	BJP	INC	Difference
Caste			
Scheduled Tribe	0.000	0.037	-0.037
Scheduled Caste	0.081	0.148	-0.067
OBC	0.284	0.259	0.025
General	0.635	0.537	0.098
Hindu	0.932	0.741	0.192***
Age	47.054	45.407	1.647
Education	14.176	13.500	0.676
Party tenure (years)	16.129	13.056	3.073
Rooms in house	4.495	4.556	-0.061
Owns car	0.716	0.722	-0.006
Times approached	15.085	20.444	-5.359
Ever fought election	0.419	0.685	-0.266***
N	74	54	128

Note:
This table shows descriptive statistics from a survey of party activists conducted in Jaipur and Kota districts of Rajasthan. Significance stars: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

C.2 Household survey

Household survey sampling was done in three stages. In Stage 1, I selected the primary sampling units (PSUs)—Gram Panchayats in rural areas and municipal wards in urban regions. Since the concentration of women-focused party activities is higher in and around urban areas, and to minimize enumerators' travel distance and time during Covid, I listed municipalities and Block/Panchayat Samiti headquarters within a ∼60 km radius of the three main city centers.[1] Then blocking on gender-based reservation status of municipal ward councilors and Gram Panchayat Sarpanches, and their party affiliations (BJP or INC), I sampled an equal number of municipal wards and Gram Panchayats in each district.[2] Figure C.2 shows the locations where the survey took place in each district.

The second stage was to identify households. Each PSU was assigned a randomly generated "start number" corresponding to a voter's position on the PSU's electoral roll. Enumerators located this voter's residence and ascertained if a man and a woman of voting age were present in the household at that time. If yes, they proceeded to select respondents and conduct the survey. If these conditions were not met, or if consent could not be obtained, enumerators visited the next house to the right. This process was repeated until until a survey was completed. After a successful survey, enumerators skipped five houses to the right and repeated this process.

The final stage was to identify respondents. Husbands and wives are ideal respondent pairs as the majority of women of voting age are also married, and husbands are often the most critical gatekeepers. However, men's work schedules made it difficult to *always* use husband-wife pairs.[3] Hence, I expanded permissible pairings, while still retaining the gatekeeping relationship between respondents. Within a household, enumerators noted the age of the eldest male member present at that time. Next, they listed the names of all women younger than him, present in the house, in descending order of age. The final selection of the female respondent–also designated the primary respondent–was made through a household-specific Kish table. The female respondent was then asked, among the men who were present in the house at that time and elder to her, with whom she had the most political conversations. This person was the male, or secondary, respondent.[4] Both interviews were conducted simultaneously and privately so that respondents could not hear or influence each other's answers. Typically, the male respondent was interviewed in their living room or porch while the female respondent was interviewed in a separate room inside the house.

The surveys adhered to strict quality standards: I was present on the field throughout the survey and accompanied enumerators to the field each day. Enumerators were given daily feedback, trained how to help the respondent understand survey questions, as well as demeanour, especially when interacting with women respondents.

Interviews with party activists were more challenging than household surveys. Enumerators had limited experience with elite surveys; activists expected some background knowledge of their party, were impatient, and could get fatigued with standard survey procedures. Moreover, the limited respondent pool inhibited the replacement of non-respondents. For these reasons, I trained enumerators myself intensively over a period of one week. Training included modules on party history, key local leaders, guided tours of party offices, introductions with office chiefs, participant observation, and informal interactions with party workers and key informants. This helped enumerators overcome their inhibitions in front of high-ranking office bearers, built

[1] I had to make an exception to this in Jodhpur as there were an insufficient number of municipalities within the specified radius.

[2] Municipal ward councilors' party affiliation is publicly available on their election records. Sarpanches' party affiliations were collected through a short telephonic survey. I dropped PSUs from the sampling frame if their representatives were not reachable or did not reveal party affiliation.

[3] It was also not possible to survey wives during the day and husbands in the evening due to covid-related evening curfews.

[4] See pre-analysis plan for a sample cover page used to select respondents. The age rule was relaxed by a few years in case the original secondary respondent was not in a position to be interviewed or did not provide consent.

domain knowledge, and equipped them to handle unexpected field situations. During survey scale-up, I conducted several interviews myself in the presence of enumerators to help understand how to frame and explain questions and handle respondents' concerns. Subsequently, I conducted fewer interviews myself, but conducted random checks and monitoring to ensure data collection proceeded smoothly.

Figure C.1: Relationship of male respondent to female respondent

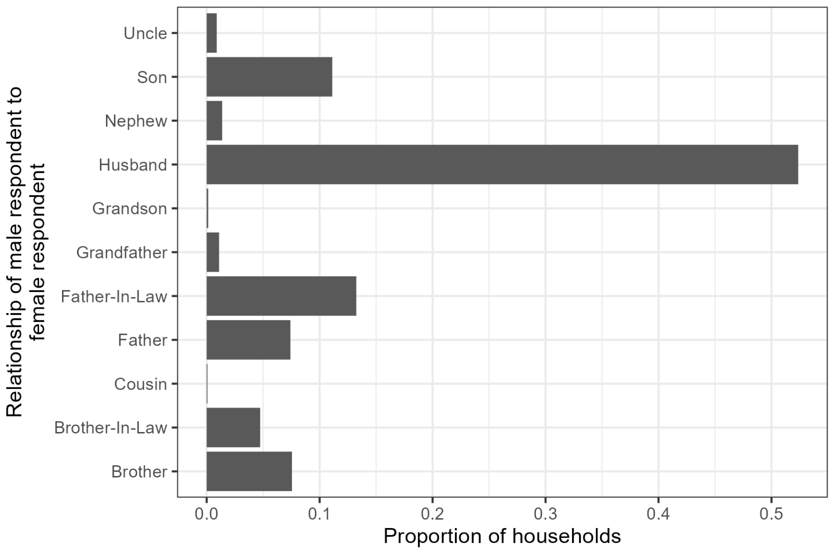


Figure C.2: Map of PSUs

(a) Jaipur (b) Jodhpur (c) Kota

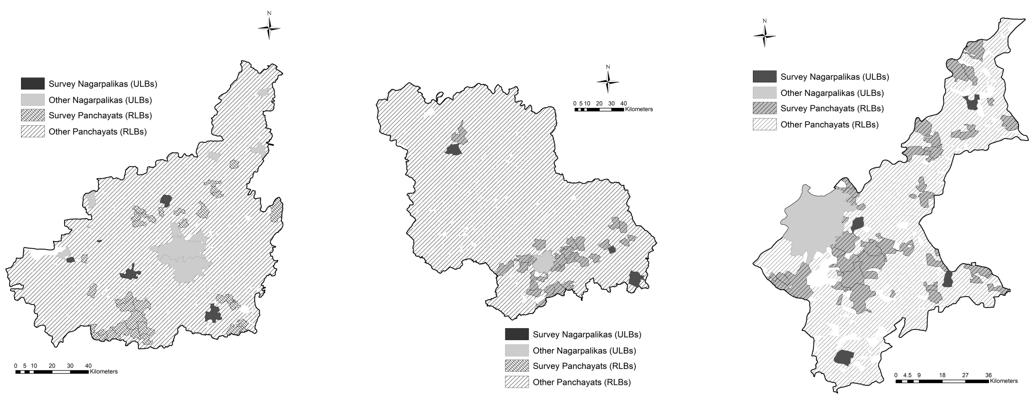


Table C.3: Descriptive statistics by sex (HH survey)

		Men				Women				W-M
Variable	n	Mean	SD	Min	Max	Mean	SD	Min	Max	Difference
Caste: General	1457	0.12	0.33	0	1	0.16	0.36	0	1	0.03***
Caste: ST	1457	0.13	0.33	0	1	0.11	0.32	0	1	-0.01
Caste: SC	1457	0.25	0.44	0	1	0.22	0.41	0	1	-0.04**
Caste: OBC	1457	0.48	0.50	0	1	0.51	0.50	0	1	0.03
Caste: SBC	1457	0.01	0.12	0	1	0.00	0.04	0	1	-0.01***
Hindu	1457	0.91	0.29	0	1	0.91	0.29	0	1	0
Age	1457	40.83	15.16	18	95	34.19	11.97	18	75	-6.65***
Education (years)	1457	8.60	4.83	0	18	5.75	5.66	0	17	-2.85***
N rooms	1457	3.06	1.91	0	24	3.06	1.91	0	24	0
Religion important	1457	3.85	0.51	1	4	3.65	0.59	1	4	-0.2***
Vote National	1457	0.88	0.33	0	1	0.75	0.43	0	1	-0.12***
Vote State	1457	0.87	0.34	0	1	0.68	0.47	0	1	-0.19***
Vote Local	1457	0.89	0.31	0	1	0.76	0.43	0	1	-0.13***
Participate: Campaigned for party	1457	0.39	0.49	0	1	0.17	0.38	0	1	-0.22***
Participate: Political event	1457	0.47	0.50	0	1	0.19	0.39	0	1	-0.28***
Participate: Encouraged others to vote	1457	0.56	0.50	0	1	0.33	0.47	0	1	-0.23***
Participate: Protest	1457	0.16	0.36	0	1	0.03	0.17	0	1	-0.13***
Participate: Seva	1457	0.32	0.47	0	1	0.05	0.21	0	1	-0.27***
Participate: Religious seva	1457	0.75	0.43	0	1	0.54	0.50	0	1	-0.21***
Participate: Any seva	1457	0.80	0.40	0	1	0.56	0.50	0	1	-0.24***
BJP ID	1457	0.55	0.50	0	1	0.53	0.50	0	1	-0.02
INC ID	1457	0.35	0.48	0	1	0.39	0.49	0	1	0.04**
Political knowledge: NREGS	1457	0.57	0.49	0	1	0.16	0.37	0	1	-0.41***
Political knowledge: Ujjwala	1457	0.81	0.40	0	1	0.58	0.49	0	1	-0.23***
Political knowledge: Reservation status	1457	0.87	0.33	0	1	0.71	0.45	0	1	-0.16***
Veil: Elders	1457	0.85	0.36	0	1	0.90	0.29	0	1	0.06***
Veil: Public	1457	0.77	0.42	0	1	0.90	0.30	0	1	0.13***
Permission: Market	1457	0.78	0.41	0	1	0.91	0.29	0	1	0.12***
Permission: Friends & Neighbors	1457	0.55	0.50	0	1	0.56	0.50	0	1	0.01
Permission: Parent's home	1457	0.89	0.31	0	1	0.93	0.23	0	1	0.04***
Permission: Seva	1457	0.78	0.41	0	1	0.90	0.29	0	1	0.12***
Permission: Protest	1457	0.92	0.28	0	1	0.88	0.32	0	1	-0.03***
Permission: Party campaign	1457	0.91	0.29	0	1	0.89	0.32	0	1	-0.02*
Permission: Travel on public transport	1457	0.93	0.25	0	1	0.93	0.25	0	1	0

Note: $^{*}p<0.1$; $^{**}p<0.05$; $^{***}p<0.01$ This table shows descriptive statistics of the household survey by sex. SBC refers to Special Backward Classes. Veiling and permission variables refer to the proportion of women observing the practice or seeking permission, and the proportion of men who consider it appropriate for women to observe the practice or seek permission.

D Experimental design

D.1 Conjoint experiment

Parties and leaders organize different kinds of programs from time to time. As you know, these days many women are voting and taking part in these programs. I will now ask you some questions about the kinds of events you think that [**you/women in your family**] would like to attend.

Please imagine this situation: There is an election coming up, and two candidates are trying to get an election ticket. These candidates are planning to organize an event near your neighborhood. When they organize this, they will invite women, including [**you/name of female respondent**] to attend. I will now tell you a little bit about these candidates and the event they plan to organize.

This is the [**first/second**] candidate:

1. **[He/she]** is a **[man/woman]**
2. **[He/she]** is a member of [***jati***], which is a part of the [**caste**] community

Table D.1: List of *jatis* and caste categories

Jati	**Caste Group**
Own *Jati*	Own Caste
Sharma (Brahmin)	Upper Caste
Chauhan (Rajput)	Upper Caste
Agarwal (Bania)	Upper Caste
Pasi	Scheduled Caste
Baerwa	Scheduled Caste
Dhobi	Scheduled Caste

3. **[He/she]** wants to get a ticket from **[BJP/INC]**
4. **[He/she]** is interested in running for office in the next election from your constituency and is planning to organize a [**public meeting/*seva* program/peaceful protest**] to work towards the development of this area.
5. In your neighborhood, [**few/many**] women have expressed an interest in attending this.
6. In your neighborhood, [**few/many**] men are willing to let women in their family attend this.

Outcome Questions:

1. Unfortunately, both events will be held at the same time, so people can only attend one of them. If **[you/name of female respondent]** had to attend one of these events (and she asked you), which one would you like (her) to attend?
2. On a scale of 1-10, how much did you like:
   (a) the first profile,
   (b) the second profile,

   where 1 means that you did not like it at all, 5 means you like it to some extent and 10 means that you liked it a lot?
3. *[For women respondents only]* Now if your family had a say in where you should go, which one would they choose for you?
4. *[After the last task only]* Why did you choose this profile?

D.2 Political communication experiment

As you know, elections were held over the last 1-2 years to choose your [Sarpanch / Councilor]. But because of COVID, many new leaders have not been able to meet with voters. Many leaders we have spoken with so far have expressed an interest in being able to interact with voters to know what their problems are and how to solve them. But only after things become completely normal, and we defeat Covid. They are then thinking about organizing an event to mobilize people in their areas.

The purpose of this event will be to engage with voters and start working for the development of this [village/ward]. We will do this through a [peaceful protest/*samaj seva* event]. The event will start with an address by your leader. After that, [there will be a march where we will shout slogans/we will do *seva* and a *padyatra*] and get other people in the area to join. This will help others know about how the party is working to make people's lives better and show people how they can contribute to make their community better.

[Enumerator: Now please place the 1-10 ladder in front of the respondent.]

1. Do you like or dislike this idea? Can you tell me on a scale of 1-10, where 1 means you dislike it completely, 5 means you are neutral, and 10 means that you like it completely?
2. If I were to ask 10 men in your *mohalla* about this, how many of them do you think would attend this?
3. If I were to ask 10 women in your *mohalla* about this, how many of them do you think would attend this?

Main outcome question:
Thank you for your opinion. To help your representative make a decision about holding this event or not, we would like to tell them what people in their constituency think.

Are you willing to share this opinion to your representative? If you choose to do so, [we will not disclose your decision or your name to anyone inside or outside the household, including the other respondent and your representative/ we will not disclose your name to anyone outside the household, including your representative, but your family will know/ we will publish your name in a newspaper a few days after we complete this survey, and also share your name with your representative. So, people in your family, members of your community and your representative will come to know that you sent your opinion].

There will be no direct or indirect benefit to you from sharing your opinion except for helping your leader decide what the people want. But if you don't want to share this opinion with your representative, that is also totally fine. So you have two options: (1) send your opinion to your *Sarpanch/Parshad*, (2) not send your opinion. What would you like to do?[5]

[5] Respondents in the non-anonymous conditions were debriefed at the end of the survey about the hypothetical nature of the event, and whether they would like to see their name published in a local newspaper.

E Survey questions

This appendix contains survey questions used to collect data cited in the article.

E.1 Political activists

E.1.1 Grassroots organizing

1. Party activists often organize events when there are no elections going on. For example, the party may call you when a big leader has come, to attend a rally, to religious and cultural programs, *samaj seva* events, or protests and demonstrations. During the last three months, how many times did the party organize such events?
2. How many of them were *seva* events?
3. And how many were protests and demonstrations?

E.2 Household survey

E.2.1 Permission and gatekeeping

Women: Do you ask for permission when going out to:
Men: Do you think women should ask for permission when going out to:
(Options are Yes/No/Not permitted-recoded to Permission needed):

1. Buy things from the market
2. Visit women in other *mohallas* to talk
3. Go to parent's home
4. Go for a *samaj seva* program
5. Take part in a protest
6. Take part in election campaigns
7. Make a long distance trip using public transport

E.2.2 Veiling

Women: Do you observe *ghunghat/purdah* when:
Men: Do you think women should observe *ghunghat/purdah* when: (Options are Yes/No):

1. Before elders
2. Going outside the house (in public spaces)

E.2.3 Brand association

When you think about the following parties, which one do you most associate with each of the following activities?
Options are: BJP, INC, Both, Neither/Don't know

1. Social service (*seva*)
2. Protests

E.2.4 List of covariates

1. Age in years
2. Education in years: this will be calculated from the highest level of education completed.
3. Caste: indicators for whether the respondent belongs to the SC, ST, OBC, SBC or General category
4. Religion: whether Hindu or not
5. Wealth as measured through number of rooms in the dwelling and asset ownership
6. Religiosity index: This is an average of private and public religious practice indexes
   - Private: In the last year, how frequently did you: (a) Pray at home, (b) Watch religious programs on TV (c) Think religion is very important for me
   - Public: In the last year, how frequently did you (a) do religious *seva*? (b) visit a temple or mosque? [Absent for Muslim women], (c) During the last year, did you participate in a public *puja/jamat*, (d) *Dharmik Katha*? [Absent for Muslims], (e) *Kalash Yatra/juloos*?
7. Political participation index: Index of:
   - Voting Index: Did you vote in the last (a) Lok Sabha election, (b) Vidhan Sabha election, (c) Ward/Panchayat election
   - Public Participation Index: Have you ever: (a) Campaigned for a political party or candidate? (b) Attended an election rally/meeting?, (c) Donated or collected money for a candidate or a party?
8. Political knowledge index: index combining (a) Which central government started the NREGA Rozgar guarantee scheme, (b) Which central government started the Ujjwala Yojana that provides subsidized cooking gas connections?, (c) What is the name of your MP/Saansad?, (d) What is the name of your MLA/Vidhayak?, (e) During the recent election Sarapanch/Ward election, was this seat reserved for women

F Pre-analysis Plan

F.1 Hypotheses

This paper is based on a book project on how religiously conservative parties mobilize women. The attached pre-analysis plan contains the hypotheses for the book project. This paper only tests a subset of the pre-registered hypotheses.

1. The BJP uses norm-compliant frames more than norm-undermining mobilization frames
   (a) A larger proportion of the BJP's events for women will be based on *seva* than other parties.
   (b) A larger proportion of the BJP's events for women will be based on *seva* than protests
   (c) The BJP is more likely to mention *seva* in its political communication than other parties.
   (d) The BJP is more likely to mention *seva* than protests in its political communication.
   (e) BJP activists are more likely to perceive a woman with a background in *seva*-related activities as similar to them, compared to other parties.
   (f) BJP activists are more likely to perceive a woman with a background in *seva*-related activities as similar to them, compared to a woman with a background in protest-related activities.
2. Women's preferences
   (a) More women will have taken part in *seva* than protests
   (b) Women will prefer *seva* events as compared to protests
3. Men's preferences
   (a) Men will prefer *seva* events as compared to protests for themselves
4. Social norms
   (a) Respondents are more likely to perceive women as more interested in *seva* as compared to protests.
   (b) More women will need permission to attend *seva* events as compared to protests or political campaigns.
   (c) Respondents will prefer events where a larger number of women are interested in attending.
5. Men's gatekeeping
   (a) Men will prefer women attend *seva* events as compared to protests.
   (b) Respondents are more likely to choose the event that other men prefer.
   (c) Respondents will place a higher weight to men's preferences of event than women's own interest.

F.2 Variable construction

F.2.1 Imputing missing values for covariates

I replace missing values with sex $\times$ randomization block means.

F.2.2 Index construction

To reduce the number of covariates in regressions, I will create composite indexes for variables that are closely related. This will be done as follows:

- For all outcomes, switch signs where necessary so that the positive direction always indicates a higher outcome.
- Impute missing values using the procedure defined above
- If all variables are measured on the same scale, the index is the mean of these variables
- If variables are measured on different scales, calculate z-scores for each variable such that the mean is 0 and the standard deviation is 1. The index is the mean of these z-scores.

F.2.3 Party ID

- Use response of "Which party's *vichardhara* do you like?"
- If the response does not identify a unique party, then examine voting patterns. If the person has voted for the same party in more than 50% elections—national, state or local (only for urban)—then assign them to that party.
- If party ID is still missing, assign them to their family's party ID as mentioned by the respondent.
- If party ID is still missing and the paired respondent in the same household has identified a unique party ID for the household, assign the respondent to that ID.

F.3 Deviations

F.3.1 Conjoint experiment

1. The conjoint experiment was designed as giving equal weight to all levels in the caste attribute. SC and general categories had three sub-levels—SC: Pasi, Baerwa, and Dhobi, and General: Sharma (Brahmin), Chauhan (Rajput), and Agarwal (Bania). There were no sub-levels for "own caste." Hence the correct weights were 1/9 for each sub-level; and 3/9 for each level. However, due to a coding error in the questionnaire, the "own caste" level was taken as a sub-level with a weight of 1/7 instead of 1/3. This change does not present analytical challenges in assessing the impact of the caste attribute, and it does not impact the impact of other attributes, which I show through different specifications in Table G.2. The preferred specification in this article uses co-ethnicity based on matching caste categories of the respondent with the candidate characteristic. This is because coethnic (vs. non-co-ethnic) is the estimate of interest rather than caste identity *per se*.
2. I pre-registered an OLS-based analytical method to estimate the AMCEs in alignment with Hainmueller et al. (2014). However in the light of advances in estimation methods, I present marginal means corrected for swapping bias (Clayton et al. 2023) in Appendix G.

F.3.2 Political communication experiment

The political communication experiment was designed to conduct an exploratory analysis of whether framing and visibility were more effective in easing or intensifying private or public constraints to women's participatio. The relevant comparisons in this case would be comparing opinion transmission under anonymity to transmission under partial (household) or complete (household + public + representative) visibility. However, enumerator teams encountered logistical issues in separating women respondents from *other women* in the home, especially when respondents had to do household chores while answering questions, or in small dwellings. This made the anonymous and partial visibility groups similar. Hence, to maximize power, I pool the anonymous and partial visibility groups and compare them with the complete visibility group. Results do not change if the partial visibility group is excluded from the analysis (Table H.3). In addition, we control for external observation. Individual fixed effects in the conjoint mean that the AMCEs and marginal means are unaffected. Results change negligibly in the political communication experiment (Table H.2).

F.3.3 Covariates

The political knowledge index was to be based on an index of whether people were able to correctly recall the names of their national and state-level representatives (MP and MLA), their local reservation status, and identify the party in power when two welfare programs (NREGS and *Ujjwala*) were implemented. However, due to a coding error in the questionnaire, women in urban areas did not receive the question about their representative. I therefore exclude those questions when calculating the index for all respondents.

G Conjoint experiment

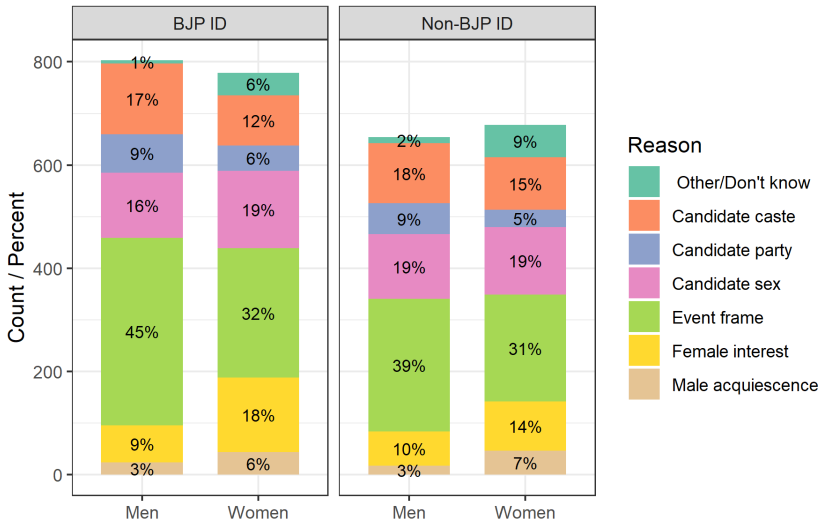
G.1 Main effects

Table G.1: Conjoint experiment: AMCE estimates

		Choice			Rating			Family choice
		Pooled	Women	Men	Pooled	Women	Men	Women
Event frame	Seva	0.079***	0.066***	0.093***	0.191***	0.112	0.274***	0.053**
		(0.015)	(0.022)	(0.021)	(0.062)	(0.081)	(0.095)	(0.021)
		[<0.001]	[0.002]	[<0.001]	[0.002]	[0.166]	[0.004]	[0.013]
		{<0.001}	{0.006}	{<0.001}	{0.004}	{0.232}	{0.009}	{0.019}
Event frame	Protest	-0.060***	-0.036	-0.085***	-0.246***	-0.139	-0.350***	-0.055**
		(0.015)	(0.022)	(0.022)	(0.063)	(0.083)	(0.094)	(0.022)
		[<0.001]	[0.099]	[<0.001]	[<0.001]	[0.093]	[<0.001]	[0.012]
		{<0.001}	{0.139}	{<0.001}	{<0.001}	{0.216}	{0.002}	{0.019}
Women's interest	High	0.038***	0.040**	0.037**	0.165***	0.210***	0.119	0.044**
		(0.012)	(0.017)	(0.017)	(0.051)	(0.067)	(0.076)	(0.017)
		[0.002]	[0.019]	[0.034]	[0.001]	[0.002]	[0.115]	[0.010]
		{0.002}	{0.033}	{0.039}	{0.003}	{0.007}	{0.161}	{0.019}
Men's assent	Many	0.080***	0.080***	0.080***	0.283***	0.330***	0.242***	0.074***
		(0.012)	(0.017)	(0.017)	(0.050)	(0.065)	(0.077)	(0.018)
		[<0.001]	[<0.001]	[<0.001]	[<0.001]	[<0.001]	[0.002]	[<0.001]
		{<0.001}	{<0.001}	{<0.001}	{<0.001}	{<0.001}	{0.006}	{<0.001}
Candidate co-ethnic	Yes	0.055***	0.033	0.078***	0.090	0.056	0.131	0.049**
		(0.015)	(0.021)	(0.021)	(0.065)	(0.085)	(0.097)	(0.021)
		[<0.001]	[0.120]	[<0.001]	[0.165]	[0.515]	[0.179]	[0.022]
		{<0.001}	{0.140}	{<0.001}	{0.193}	{0.515}	{0.209}	{0.026}
Candidate sex	Woman	0.069***	0.078***	0.059***	0.143***	0.084	0.199**	0.071***
		(0.012)	(0.017)	(0.017)	(0.050)	(0.066)	(0.074)	(0.018)
		[<0.001]	[<0.001]	[<0.001]	[0.004]	[0.203]	[0.007]	[<0.001]
		{<0.001}	{<0.001}	{<0.001}	{0.006}	{0.237}	{0.013}	{<0.001}
Candidate party	BJP	0.002	0.002	0.002	0.048	0.104	-0.014	-0.017
		(0.012)	(0.017)	(0.018)	(0.051)	(0.068)	(0.077)	(0.017)
		[0.868]	[0.922]	[0.904]	[0.351]	[0.123]	[0.854]	[0.322]
		{0.868}	{0.922}	{0.904}	{0.351}	{0.216}	{0.854}	{0.322}
FE Individual		Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
N respondents		2914	1457	1457	2914	1457	1457	1457
N Observations		11656	5828	5828	11656	5828	5828	5818

Note: Estimates of AMCEs from the conjoint experiment using pre-specified OLS regression per Hainmueller et al. (2015). Cluster-robust standard errors are reported in parentheses, uncorrected p-values in square brackets, and Benjamini-Hochberg adjusted p-values in curly brackets. Multiple-testing adjustment is carried out within sample × outcome families using the BH false discovery rate procedure. Significance stars are based on BH adjusted p-values: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, and * $p < 0.10$. All specifications include individual fixed effects.

Figure G.1: Reason for choosing profile (conjoint experiment)



Note: This figure shows the main reason why respondents chose a particular profile in the last task.

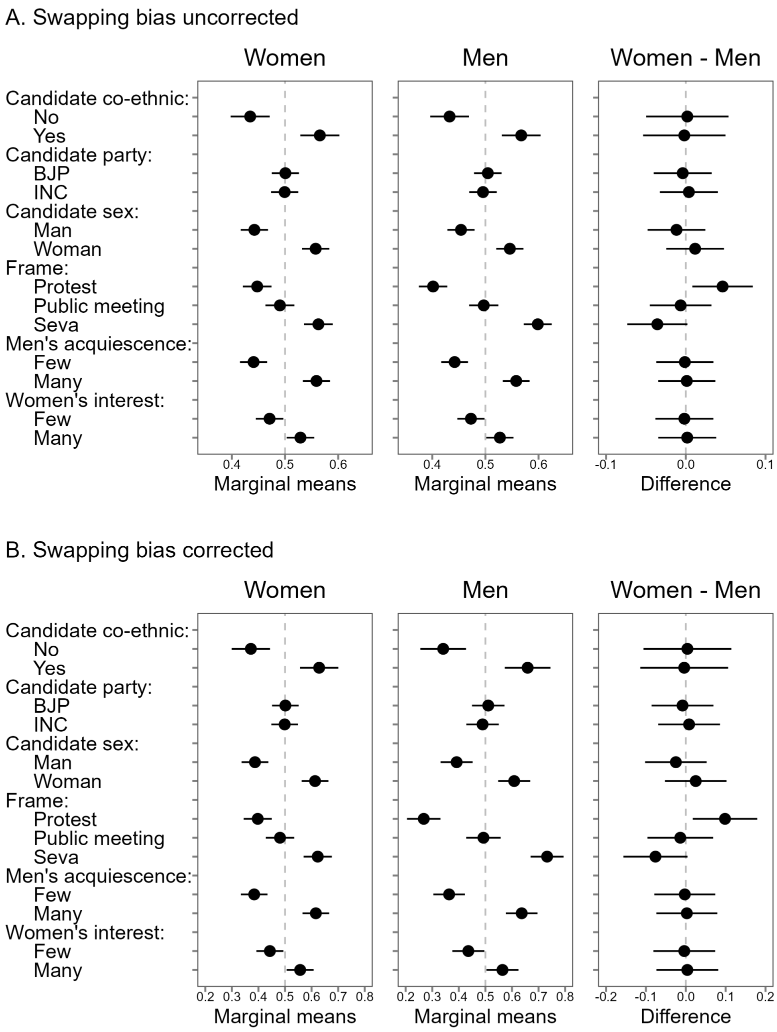
G.2 Robustness checks

Table G.2: Re-estimating caste AMCE based on pre-specified method (Conjoint experiment)

	Dependent variable:									
	Choice				Rating				Family choice	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)	(9)	(10)
Party:BJP	0.002	0.002	0.002	0.003	0.104	−0.014	0.104	−0.015	−0.017	−0.017
	(0.017)	(0.018)	(0.017)	(0.018)	(0.068)	(0.077)	(0.068)	(0.077)	(0.017)	(0.017)
Cand:Female	0.078***	0.059***	0.078***	0.059***	0.084	0.199***	0.085	0.196***	0.071***	0.072***
	(0.017)	(0.017)	(0.017)	(0.017)	(0.066)	(0.074)	(0.066)	(0.074)	(0.018)	(0.018)
Caste:Co-ethnic	0.033	0.078***			0.056	0.131			0.049**	
	(0.021)	(0.021)			(0.085)	(0.097)			(0.021)	
Caste:SC			−0.093***	−0.092***			−0.220**	−0.223*		−0.106***
			(0.027)	(0.027)			(0.105)	(0.120)		(0.027)
Caste:Gen			−0.079***	−0.093***			−0.179*	−0.116		−0.083***
			(0.027)	(0.027)			(0.106)	(0.120)		(0.027)
Frame:Protest	−0.036*	−0.085***	−0.035	−0.086***	−0.139*	−0.350***	−0.137*	−0.352***	−0.055**	−0.053**
	(0.022)	(0.022)	(0.022)	(0.022)	(0.083)	(0.094)	(0.083)	(0.094)	(0.022)	(0.022)
Frame:Seva	0.066***	0.093***	0.066***	0.093***	0.112	0.274***	0.112	0.272***	0.053**	0.054**
	(0.022)	(0.021)	(0.022)	(0.021)	(0.081)	(0.095)	(0.081)	(0.095)	(0.021)	(0.021)
Wom. interest:High	0.040**	0.037**	0.040**	0.036**	0.210***	0.119	0.210***	0.118	0.044**	0.044**
	(0.017)	(0.017)	(0.017)	(0.017)	(0.067)	(0.076)	(0.067)	(0.076)	(0.017)	(0.017)
Men's assent:Many	0.080***	0.080***	0.080***	0.080***	0.330***	0.242***	0.330***	0.241***	0.074***	0.074***
	(0.017)	(0.017)	(0.017)	(0.017)	(0.065)	(0.077)	(0.066)	(0.077)	(0.018)	(0.018)
FE	Ind.	Ind.	Ind.	Ind.	Ind.	Ind.	Ind.	Ind.	Ind.	Ind.
N respondents	1457	1457	1457	1457	1457	1457	1457	1457	1455	1455
Sample	Women	Men	Women	Men	Women	Men	Women	Men	Women	Women
Observations	5,828	5,828	5,828	5,828	5,828	5,828	5,828	5,828	5,818	5,818

Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01. This table estimates the AMCE using different recodings of ethnicity. The pre-registered specification estimated the AMCE of SC and General compared to the respondent's own caste (Columns 3-4, 7-8, and 10). The specification preferred in this article compared co-ethnic to non-co-ethnic (1-2, 5-6, and 9). Estimates are based on pre-specified OLS regressions as recommended by Hainmueller et al. (2015). SEs are clustered at the level of the respondent.

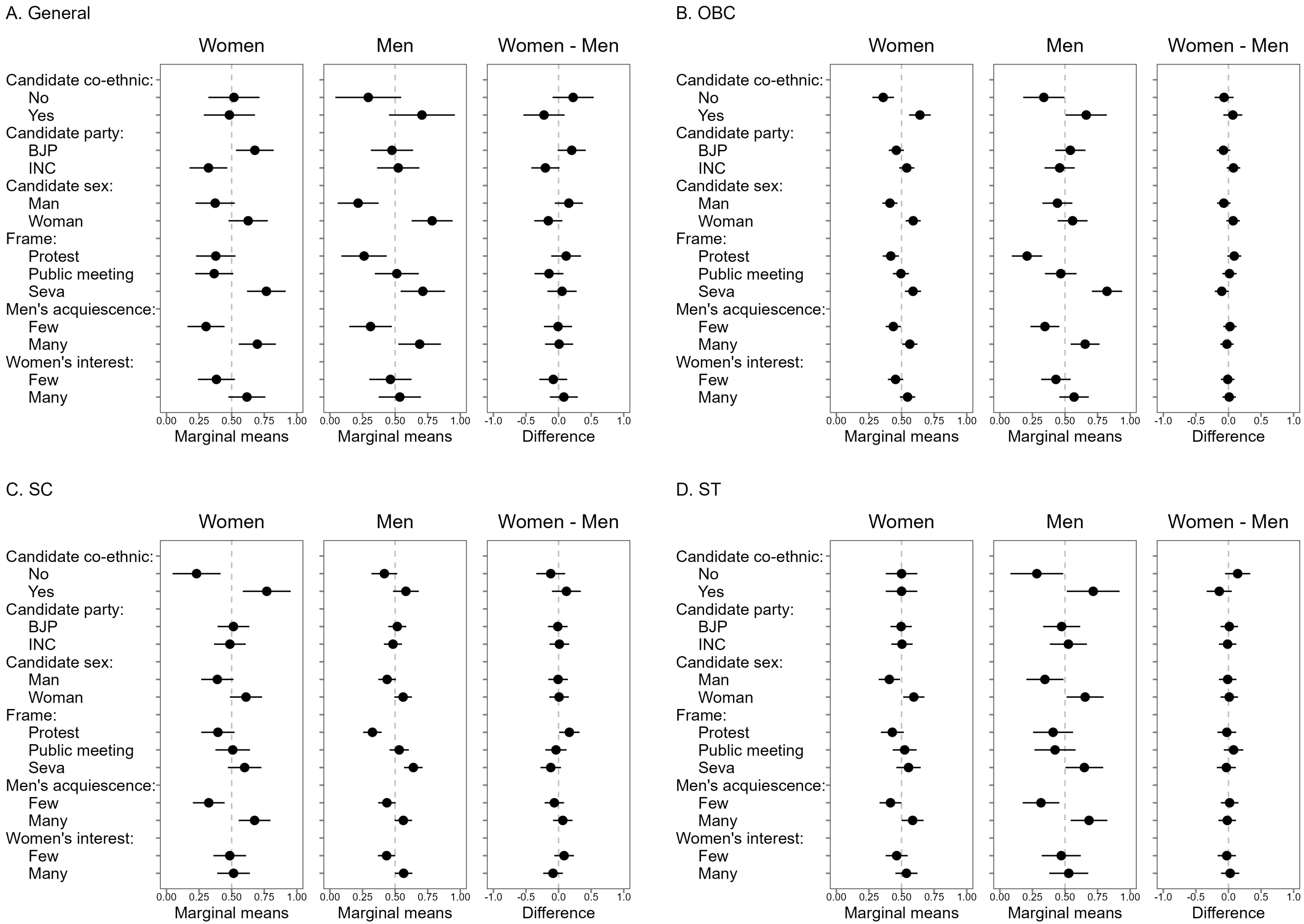
Figure G.2: Marginal means (Conjoint experiment)



Note: This plots the marginal means from the discrete choice experiment based on the choice outcome. Panel B corrects for swapping error using the algorithm developed by Clayton et al. (2023). Candidate co-ethnicity matches the caste group (not *jati*) of the candidate to the respondent. Error bars correspond to 95% confidence intervals.

G.3 Subgroup preferences

Figure G.3: Subgroup preferences by caste (Conjoint experiment)



Note: This plot shows subgroup preferences in the discrete choice experiment by respondent caste based on Clayton et al. (2023) after correcting for swapping bias with a conservative IRR floor of 0.6. The sample includes 408 General caste respondents (179 men, 229 women), 1,444 OBC respondents (703 men, 741 women), 22 SBC respondents (20 men, 2 women), 689 SC respondents (371 men, 318 women), and 351 ST respondents (184 men, 167 women). Candidate co-ethnicity matches the caste group (not *jati*) of the candidate to the respondent. Error bars correspond to 95% confidence intervals.

H Political Communication Experiment

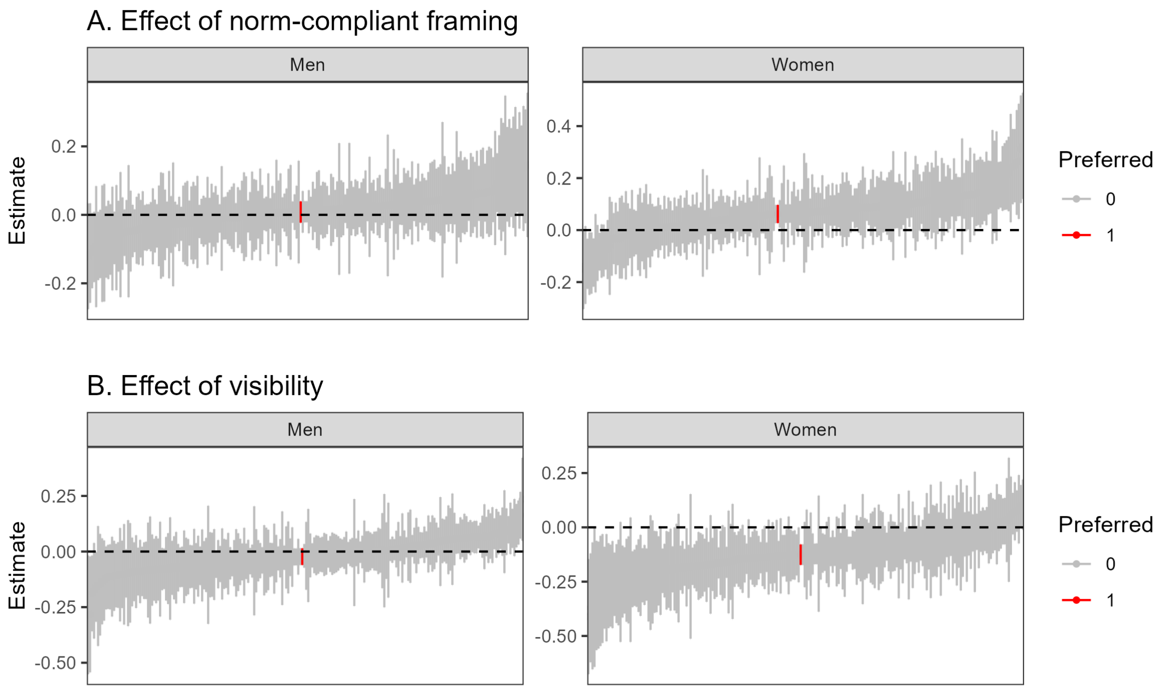
H.1 Robustness checks

Table H.1: Effect of framing and visibility on voice transmission (unadjusted estimates)

	Women			Men		
	Panel A: Effect of Frame					
	Social visibility			Social visibility		
	Pooled	Anon	Visible	Pooled	Anon	Visible
Seva	0.062***	0.036*	0.142***	0.008	-0.002	0.041
	(0.018)	(0.018)	(0.044)	(0.016)	(0.018)	(0.036)
	[<0.01]	[0.049]	[<0.01]	[0.620]	[0.914]	[0.254]
	{<0.01}	{0.097}	{<0.01}	{0.744}	{0.914}	{0.382}
Control mean	0.831	0.873	0.698	0.894	0.905	0.860
N	1,457	1,108	349	1,457	1,107	350
	Panel B: Effect of Visibility					
	Frame			Frame		
	Pooled	Seva	Protest	Pooled	Seva	Protest
Visible	-0.122***	-0.068**	-0.178***	-0.024	-0.006	-0.046
	(0.024)	(0.030)	(0.037)	(0.019)	(0.026)	(0.029)
	[<0.01]	[0.024]	[<0.01]	[0.210]	[0.830]	[0.120]
	{<0.01}	{0.047}	{<0.01}	{0.252}	{0.830}	{0.179}
Control mean	0.893	0.911	0.873	0.904	0.904	0.905
N	1,457	740	717	1,457	741	716

Note: Entries report estimates from regressions with randomization-block fixed effects. Panel A reports the effect of Seva framing relative to Protest. Panel B reports the effect of social visibility relative to anonymity/partial visibility. SEs, in parentheses, are clustered at the treatment-assignment level (household for pooled regressions, individual for gender-disaggregated regressions). Uncorrected p-values are in square brackets, and Benjamini–Hochberg adjusted p-values are in curly braces. BH correction is applied within each panel. Stars are based on BH-adjusted p-values: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

Figure H.1: Specification curve (Political communication experiment)



Note: This plots coefficient estimates of different specifications varying covariate usage, fixed effects and various sub-samples. Vertical lines represent 95% confidence intervals. The preferred specification is in red.

Table H.2: Survey privacy and effect of framing and visibility (Political communication experiment)

	Dependent variable:							
	Exercised voice							
	Women				Men			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Seva	0.062***	0.061***			0.008	0.008		
	(0.018)	(0.018)			(0.016)	(0.016)		
Visibility			−0.125***	−0.126***			−0.023	−0.024
			(0.021)	(0.021)			(0.019)	(0.019)
Age	−0.001	−0.001	−0.001	−0.001	−0.003	−0.003	−0.003	−0.003
	(0.005)	(0.005)	(0.005)	(0.005)	(0.003)	(0.003)	(0.003)	(0.003)
Age2	0.00001	0.00001	0.00001	0.00001	0.00003	0.00003	0.00003	0.00003
	(0.0001)	(0.0001)	(0.0001)	(0.0001)	(0.00003)	(0.00003)	(0.00003)	(0.00003)
Pol. Know. Idx	0.048***	0.049***	0.051***	0.051***	0.040***	0.039***	0.040***	0.039***
	(0.015)	(0.015)	(0.015)	(0.015)	(0.013)	(0.013)	(0.013)	(0.013)
Pol. Part. Idx	0.017	0.016	0.017	0.016	0.020	0.019	0.019	0.019
	(0.017)	(0.017)	(0.017)	(0.017)	(0.015)	(0.015)	(0.015)	(0.015)
Religion Idx	0.005	0.005	−0.001	−0.0005	0.021	0.022	0.020	0.021
	(0.019)	(0.019)	(0.019)	(0.019)	(0.015)	(0.015)	(0.015)	(0.015)
Education	−0.003	−0.003	−0.003	−0.003	−0.001	−0.0003	−0.001	−0.0003
	(0.002)	(0.002)	(0.002)	(0.002)	(0.002)	(0.002)	(0.002)	(0.002)
Asset Idx	−0.009	−0.009	−0.008	−0.007	0.0004	0.001	0.001	0.001
	(0.008)	(0.008)	(0.008)	(0.008)	(0.007)	(0.007)	(0.007)	(0.007)
Hindu	−0.018	−0.019	−0.026	−0.028	0.061**	0.058*	0.060**	0.057*
	(0.034)	(0.034)	(0.034)	(0.034)	(0.030)	(0.030)	(0.030)	(0.030)
Caste:OBC	−0.003	−0.004	0.002	0.001	0.040	0.038	0.041	0.039
	(0.027)	(0.027)	(0.026)	(0.026)	(0.026)	(0.026)	(0.026)	(0.026)
Caste:SBC	−0.422*	−0.426*	−0.444*	−0.451*	0.031	0.028	0.033	0.031
	(0.243)	(0.243)	(0.241)	(0.241)	(0.073)	(0.073)	(0.073)	(0.073)
Caste:SC	0.012	0.012	0.017	0.016	0.013	0.012	0.014	0.012
	(0.031)	(0.031)	(0.031)	(0.031)	(0.029)	(0.029)	(0.029)	(0.029)
Caste:ST	−0.026	−0.024	−0.020	−0.018	0.067**	0.067**	0.068**	0.068**
	(0.037)	(0.037)	(0.037)	(0.037)	(0.033)	(0.033)	(0.033)	(0.033)
Survey Pvt.		0.020		0.027		0.030		0.030
		(0.019)		(0.019)		(0.020)		(0.020)
FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Control mean	0.883	0.879	0.963	0.957	0.87	0.862	0.881	0.873
Covariates	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Observations	1,457	1,457	1,457	1,457	1,457	1,457	1,457	1,457
Note:								*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01. This table shows the effect of complete visibility on women's decision to communicate their opinions, by partisanship, using the political communication experiment. Covariate adjustment is per the pre-specified procedure. FEs are at the randomization block level. SEs are clustered at the individual level.

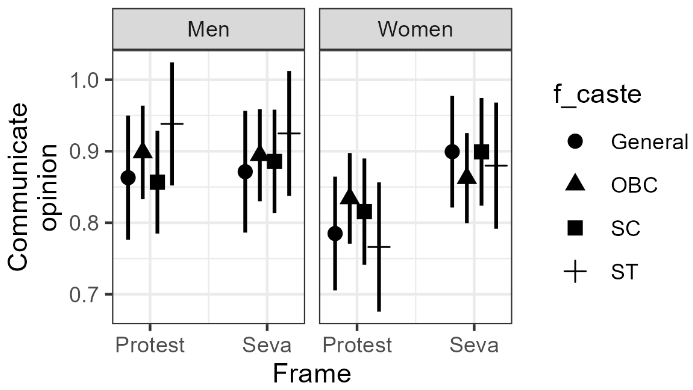
Table H.3: Effect of framing and visibility on voice (Political communication experiment)

	Exercised voice											
	Women						Men					
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)	(9)	(10)	(11)	(12)
Seva	0.061***		0.036*	0.068***		0.033	0.008		−0.002	0.016		0.002
	(0.018)		(0.020)	(0.021)		(0.025)	(0.016)		(0.018)	(0.019)		(0.022)
Visibility		−0.127***	−0.181***		−0.131***	−0.188***		−0.024	−0.047*		−0.015	−0.037
		(0.021)	(0.029)		(0.022)	(0.032)		(0.019)	(0.026)		(0.020)	(0.028)
Seva X Visibility			0.107***			0.111**			0.045			0.043
			(0.041)			(0.044)			(0.037)			(0.040)
Age	−0.001	−0.001	−0.001	−0.001	−0.001	−0.001	−0.003	−0.003	−0.003	−0.002	−0.002	−0.002
	(0.005)	(0.005)	(0.005)	(0.006)	(0.006)	(0.006)	(0.003)	(0.003)	(0.003)	(0.004)	(0.004)	(0.004)
Age2	0.00001	0.00001	0.00001	0.00001	0.00001	0.00001	0.00003	0.00003	0.00003	0.00001	0.00001	0.00001
	(0.0001)	(0.0001)	(0.0001)	(0.0001)	(0.0001)	(0.0001)	(0.00003)	(0.00003)	(0.00003)	(0.00004)	(0.00004)	(0.00004)
Pol. Know. Idx	0.049***	0.052***	0.051***	0.043**	0.046***	0.045***	0.039***	0.039***	0.039***	0.041**	0.041***	0.041***
	(0.015)	(0.015)	(0.015)	(0.018)	(0.017)	(0.017)	(0.013)	(0.013)	(0.013)	(0.016)	(0.016)	(0.016)
Pol. Part. Idx	0.016	0.016	0.016	0.008	0.008	0.007	0.019	0.019	0.019	0.009	0.009	0.009
	(0.017)	(0.017)	(0.017)	(0.020)	(0.020)	(0.020)	(0.015)	(0.015)	(0.015)	(0.017)	(0.017)	(0.017)
Religion Idx	0.005	−0.001	0.002	0.008	0.001	0.004	0.022	0.021	0.020	0.021	0.020	0.020
	(0.019)	(0.019)	(0.019)	(0.022)	(0.022)	(0.022)	(0.015)	(0.015)	(0.015)	(0.017)	(0.017)	(0.017)
Education	−0.003	−0.003	−0.003	−0.004	−0.004	−0.004	−0.0003	−0.0003	−0.0003	−0.0003	−0.0003	−0.0002
	(0.002)	(0.002)	(0.002)	(0.002)	(0.002)	(0.002)	(0.002)	(0.002)	(0.002)	(0.002)	(0.002)	(0.002)
Asset Idx	−0.009				−0.011	−0.013	0.001	0.001	0.001	−0.003	−0.003	−0.003
	(0.008)				(0.010)	(0.010)	(0.007)	(0.007)	(0.007)	(0.009)	(0.009)	(0.009)
Hindu	−0.019	−0.028	−0.031	−0.013	−0.029	−0.031	0.058*	0.057*	0.057*	0.092**	0.091**	0.091**
	(0.034)	(0.034)	(0.033)	(0.040)	(0.040)	(0.040)	(0.030)	(0.030)	(0.030)	(0.036)	(0.036)	(0.036)
Caste:OBC	−0.004	0.001	0.007	−0.006	−0.001	0.007	0.038	0.039	0.041	0.043	0.044	0.046
	(0.027)	(0.026)	(0.026)	(0.032)	(0.031)	(0.031)	(0.026)	(0.026)	(0.026)	(0.031)	(0.031)	(0.031)
Caste:SBC	−0.426*	−0.446*	−0.440*	0.148	0.043	0.069	0.028	0.031	0.034	0.028	0.026	0.031
	(0.243)	(0.241)	(0.240)	(0.353)	(0.350)	(0.347)	(0.073)	(0.073)	(0.073)	(0.082)	(0.082)	(0.082)
Caste:SC	0.012	0.016	0.023	−0.004	0.006	0.016	0.012	0.012	0.014	0.012	0.012	0.015
	(0.031)	(0.031)	(0.031)	(0.037)	(0.037)	(0.037)	(0.029)	(0.029)	(0.029)	(0.035)	(0.035)	(0.035)
Caste:ST	−0.024	−0.017	−0.014	−0.031	−0.022	−0.019	0.067**	0.068**	0.069**	0.072*	0.072*	0.074*
	(0.037)	(0.037)	(0.037)	(0.044)	(0.044)	(0.044)	(0.033)	(0.033)	(0.033)	(0.040)	(0.040)	(0.040)
Survey Pvt.	0.020	0.027	0.025	0.017	0.026	0.024	0.030	0.030	0.031	0.019	0.019	0.019
	(0.019)	(0.019)	(0.019)	(0.023)	(0.022)	(0.022)	(0.020)	(0.020)	(0.020)	(0.023)	(0.023)	(0.023)
Control mean	0.879	0.957	0.933	0.875	0.972	0.946	0.862	0.873	0.872	0.792	0.802	0.8
FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Sample	Full	Full	Full	Truncated	Truncated	Truncated	Full	Full	Full	Truncated	Truncated	Truncated
Observations	1,457	1,457	1,457	1,092	1,092	1,092	1,457	1,457	1,457	1,092	1,092	1,092

Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01. This table compares the result of framing and visibility on respondents' willingness to exercise voice between the full sample and truncated sample after dropping the partial partial visibility group. *Seva* and *Visibility* are binary indicators of norm-abiding framing and complete visibility respectively. Political knowledge, participation, and religion are indices calculated using the pre-registered method. Fixed effects are at the randomization-block level. SEs are clustered at the treatment-assignment level (household for pooled regressions, individual for gender-disaggregated regressions).

H.2 Heterogenous effects

Figure H.2: Subgroup preferences by caste (Political communication experiment)



Note: These plots show predicted probabilities of exercising voice by respondent caste after adjusting for pre-registered covariates with randomization block fixed effects. Error bars correspond to 95% confidence intervals.

Table H.4: Effect of traditional identity index on framing effects (Political communication experiment)

	Dependent variable:		
	Exercised voice		
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Seva	0.063^{***}	0.063^{***}	0.061^{***}
	(0.018)	(0.018)	(0.018)
Trad ID Idx	−0.011	−0.013	−0.012
	(0.017)	(0.017)	(0.017)
Seva X Trad ID Idx	0.048^{**}	0.045^{*}	0.043^{*}
	(0.023)	(0.023)	(0.023)
Constant	0.831^{***}	0.883^{***}	
	(0.014)	(0.109)	
FE	N	N	Y
Covariates	N	Y	Y
Observations	1,457	1,457	1,457

Note: $^{*}p < 0.1$;$^{**}p < 0.05$;$^{***}p < 0.01$. Based on the women's sample, this shows the moderating effect of traditional identity internalization on framing effects in determining exercising political voice. Traditional identity internalization is measured as an index combining women's self-reported importance assigned to running the home well, and maintaining their family's status within the community. Column 3 is the preferred specification. Estimates adjust for pre-registered covariates where indicated, with indexes being calculated using the pre-registered method. Fixed effects are at the randomization-block level. SEs are clustered at the individual (treatment-assignment) level.

I Participation and Partisanship

I.1 Barriers to women's public political presence

Table I.1: Constraints to women's public political engagement, by partisanship

	Reason for gender gap in political participation							
	HH resp	Interest	Awareness	Resources	Relevance	Family	Society	Don't know
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
BJP ID	0.027	−0.033*	0.015	0.015	0.005	0.060**	0.007	−0.026
	(0.031)	(0.019)	(0.018)	(0.013)	(0.007)	(0.025)	(0.018)	(0.019)
Age	0.208	0.299	2.492**	0.366	0.506	−1.692*	−0.129	0.021
	(0.742)	(0.685)	(0.941)	(0.559)	(0.310)	(0.940)	(0.747)	(1.168)
Age2	−1.764	0.211	1.741	−0.027	−0.283	0.817	0.146	1.349*
	(1.046)	(0.751)	(1.032)	(0.476)	(0.231)	(0.968)	(1.025)	(0.771)
Education	1.565	0.702	2.380***	0.138	0.327	2.292**	0.253	−3.896***
	(1.149)	(0.665)	(0.795)	(0.456)	(0.227)	(0.928)	(0.800)	(0.933)
Pol Know Index	0.051***	0.023*	0.075***	0.017	0.004	0.063**	0.061***	−0.100***
	(0.017)	(0.012)	(0.017)	(0.012)	(0.011)	(0.023)	(0.020)	(0.024)
Religiosity Index	0.071**	0.015	−0.033	−0.002	−0.008	0.042*	0.004	−0.084***
	(0.027)	(0.017)	(0.027)	(0.013)	(0.009)	(0.023)	(0.018)	(0.028)
Pol Participation Index	0.013	0.005	0.028	0.004	−0.004	0.085***	0.026	−0.017
	(0.031)	(0.016)	(0.024)	(0.013)	(0.005)	(0.028)	(0.016)	(0.028)
Hindu	−0.013	−0.021	−0.034	−0.031	−0.002	−0.054	−0.060	0.061
	(0.038)	(0.034)	(0.037)	(0.027)	(0.013)	(0.058)	(0.049)	(0.050)
Caste:OBC	0.016	−0.018	0.020	0.004	0.020*	0.034	−0.013	0.044
	(0.035)	(0.033)	(0.028)	(0.014)	(0.011)	(0.044)	(0.038)	(0.035)
Caste:SBC	0.288	−0.162***	−0.147***	−0.008	−0.017	0.205	−0.114***	0.193
	(0.371)	(0.032)	(0.037)	(0.033)	(0.015)	(0.352)	(0.029)	(0.338)
Caste:SC	−0.036	−0.042	0.090*	0.054***	0.008	0.050	−0.025	0.006
	(0.049)	(0.034)	(0.046)	(0.018)	(0.012)	(0.046)	(0.032)	(0.052)
Caste:ST	−0.108**	−0.046	−0.001	0.048	0.011	−0.003	−0.035	0.145***
	(0.048)	(0.044)	(0.060)	(0.032)	(0.013)	(0.047)	(0.037)	(0.050)
Asset Index	0.008	−0.004	0.010	−0.006	−0.004	−0.005	−0.004	−0.0002
	(0.012)	(0.010)	(0.009)	(0.006)	(0.003)	(0.007)	(0.007)	(0.009)
FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Constant	0.361	0.114	0.215	0.071	0.018	0.313	0.181	0.317
Observations	1,457	1,457	1,457	1,457	1,457	1,457	1,457	1,457

Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01. This table shows the factors underlying the gender gap in active participation based on respondents' partisanship. Women (only) were asked, Why do you think we see fewer women in politics? The dependent variables are whether women mentioned constraints imposed by household responsibilities; lack of interest; awareness/education; financial resources; relevance of politics; constraints imposed by their family; and constraints through social norms. These OLS regressions use randomization block fixed effects and covariates per the PAP. Standard errors are clustered at the randomization block level.

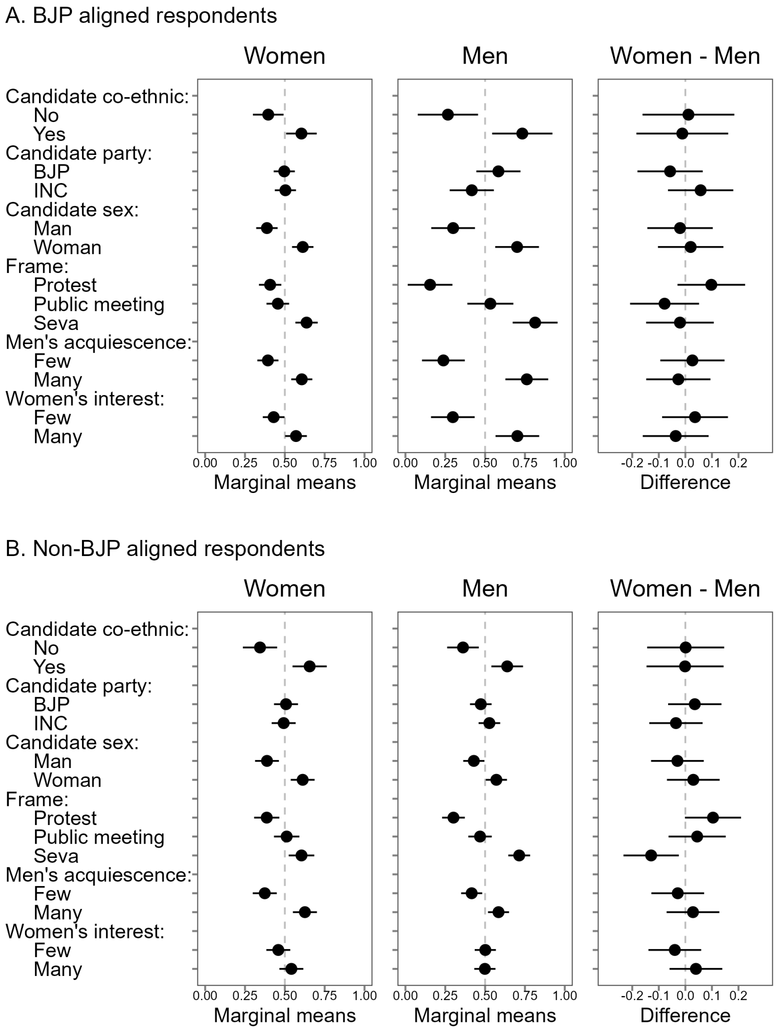
Table I.2: Permission needed for women's mobility (Household survey, male respondents)

	Permission required to go to:						
	Market	Friends	P.Home	Seva	Protest	Campaign	Pub.Transport
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)
BJP ID	0.001	−0.021	0.006	−0.049**	0.018	0.003	−0.016
	(0.024)	(0.031)	(0.020)	(0.023)	(0.017)	(0.021)	(0.014)
Age	0.103	1.258	0.523	0.626	0.367	−0.050	−0.350
	(0.340)	(0.757)	(0.343)	(0.500)	(0.369)	(0.444)	(0.268)
Age2	0.154	−0.873	−1.259***	0.164	−0.985**	−0.404	−0.127
	(0.438)	(0.611)	(0.397)	(0.514)	(0.409)	(0.297)	(0.307)
Education	−2.257***	−2.865***	−0.989**	−1.915***	−0.174	−0.820*	−0.844**
	(0.529)	(0.740)	(0.458)	(0.525)	(0.425)	(0.427)	(0.385)
Pol Know Index	−0.032*	0.002	−0.032**	−0.032*	−0.023*	−0.008	−0.002
	(0.016)	(0.023)	(0.013)	(0.018)	(0.013)	(0.016)	(0.011)
Religiosity Index	0.044***	0.063***	0.019	0.032*	0.015	0.004	0.017
	(0.016)	(0.019)	(0.018)	(0.017)	(0.013)	(0.016)	(0.013)
Pol Participation Index	−0.004	−0.004	0.002	−0.001	−0.022*	−0.014	−0.008
	(0.021)	(0.020)	(0.012)	(0.014)	(0.012)	(0.017)	(0.014)
Hindu	0.055	0.056	0.044	0.068**	−0.045*	0.007	−0.008
	(0.059)	(0.069)	(0.046)	(0.032)	(0.026)	(0.037)	(0.025)
Caste:OBC	−0.035	−0.027	0.020	0.017	0.030	0.020	0.018
	(0.036)	(0.040)	(0.032)	(0.037)	(0.024)	(0.023)	(0.024)
Caste:SBC	0.166*	−0.193	0.034	0.097	0.122***	0.078*	0.085**
	(0.085)	(0.136)	(0.055)	(0.073)	(0.031)	(0.043)	(0.034)
Caste:SC	−0.041	−0.047	0.020	0.002	−0.015	−0.023	−0.009
	(0.046)	(0.054)	(0.041)	(0.044)	(0.026)	(0.027)	(0.024)
Caste:ST	0.021	−0.110**	0.030	0.025	0.028	0.020	−0.002
	(0.048)	(0.049)	(0.043)	(0.037)	(0.032)	(0.035)	(0.044)
Asset Index	0.008	−0.007	0.009	0.032**	−0.003	−0.001	0.011
	(0.014)	(0.011)	(0.012)	(0.012)	(0.006)	(0.006)	(0.008)
FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Non-BJP ID mean	0.775	0.54	0.884	0.798	0.908	0.902	0.942
Observations	1,457	1,457	1,457	1,457	1,457	1,457	1,457

Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01. Based on the male sub-sample of the household survey, this table shows the differential mobility requirements for men identifying themselves as BJP partisans. The dependent variables are whether men require women in their family to seek permission when going to the market, meeting friends, parental homes, for *seva*-, protest-, or campaign- related activities, or a distant place using public transport. These OLS regressions use randomization block fixed effects and covariates per the PAP. Standard errors are clustered at the randomization block level.

I.2 Heterogeneous effects

Figure I.1: Subgroup preferences by partisan alignment (Conjoint experiment)



Note: This plot shows subgroup preferences in the discrete choice experiment by the respondent's partisan alignment caste correcting for swapping bias using Clayton et al. (2023). Error bars correspond to 95% confidence intervals.

Table I.3: Effect of framing and visibility on exercising voice among women respondents by BJP identification

	BJP ID = 1			BJP ID = 0			Diff. (1 − 0)		
	Panel A: Frame								
	Social visibility			Social visibility			Social visibility		
	Pooled	Anon	Visible	Pooled	Anon	Visible	Pooled	Anon	Visible
Seva	0.071**	0.038	0.189**	0.039	0.022	0.139	0.031	0.014	0.090
	(0.025)	(0.024)	(0.072)	(0.026)	(0.029)	(0.065)	(0.036)	(0.038)	(0.089)
	[<0.01]	[0.120]	[<0.01]	[0.131]	[0.451]	[0.033]	[0.381]	[0.705]	[0.309]
	{0.038}	{0.235}	{0.043}	{0.235}	{0.507}	{0.100}	{0.490}	{0.705}	{0.464}
Control mean	0.824	0.877	0.651	0.839	0.870	0.744	-0.014	0.007	-0.093
N	779	609	170	678	499	179	1,457	1,108	349
	Panel B: Visibility								
	Frame			Frame			Frame		
	Pooled	Seva	Protest	Pooled	Seva	Protest	Pooled	Seva	Protest
Visible	-0.161***	-0.086*	-0.244***	-0.090**	-0.044	-0.130**	-0.072	-0.034	-0.116
	(0.035)	(0.042)	(0.053)	(0.033)	(0.042)	(0.054)	(0.049)	(0.060)	(0.074)
	[<0.01]	[0.043]	[<0.01]	[<0.01]	[0.293]	[0.016]	[0.141]	[0.576]	[0.117]
	{<0.01}	{0.078}	{<0.01}	{0.021}	{0.329}	{0.037}	{0.181}	{0.576}	{0.176}
Control mean	0.900	0.920	0.877	0.884	0.899	0.870	0.016	0.021	0.007
N	779	409	370	678	331	347	1,457	740	717

Note: The sample is restricted to women respondents. Entries report estimates from covariate-adjusted regressions with randomization-block fixed effects, pre-specified covariates, and whether the interview was private. Columns split respondents by BJP identification. Difference columns report BJP ID = 1 minus BJP ID = 0 and are estimated using pooled interaction models; their SEs and p-values test whether the relevant treatment effect differs across BJP identification groups. Panel A reports the effect of norm-abiding framing relative to norm-challenging framing. Panel B reports the effect of social visibility relative to anonymity/partial visibility. SEs, in parentheses, are clustered at the treatment-assignment level. Uncorrected p-values are in square brackets, and Benjamini–Hochberg adjusted p-values are in curly braces. BH correction is applied within each panel. Stars are based on BH-adjusted p-values: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

J Complementary explanations

This section evaluates four theoretically distinct mechanisms moderate the framing effects reported in the main text. Together they map onto attitudinal, instrumental, structural, and behavioral domains: attitudinal accounts highlight gendered beliefs and values; instrumental accounts focus on the material and symbolic returns to partisan alignment, structural accounts emphasize organizational capacity, and behavioral accounts highlight correcting misperceived norms. I proxy conservative attitudes through religiosity, instrumental incentives through welfare programs and value-signaling, and structural reach through the BJP's organizational penetration. Because the experimental design already addresses confounding, these mechanisms are assessed as complementary, rather than competing explanations.

J.1 Attitudinal explanations

J.1.1 Religion and religiosity

Research finds religiosity can be used as a proxy for conservative attitudes in contexts where religion in salient (Norris and Inglehart 2011). At the same time Chhibber and Shastri (2014) contend that in India, religion is associated with increased political participation. To measure religiosity, I combine two indexes of religiosity and religious practice. The private religiosity index combines standardized measures of self-assessments of religiosity, frequency of private worship and viewership of religious TV channels, while the public religiosity index combines frequency of visits to places of worship, and taking part in a variety of religious festivals. Similarly, the political participation index combines measures of voting, involvement in election campaigns, attendance at rallies and public meetings, donation collection, as well as participation in party events outside of electoral periods.

Table J.1: Association between religiosity and political participation

	Dependent variable:					
	Political Participation Index					
	Pooled	Women	Men	Pooled	Women	Men
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Rel. Index	0.160***	0.185***	0.138***			
	(0.022)	(0.035)	(0.029)			
Rel. Pub. Index				0.125***	0.139***	0.110***
				(0.012)	(0.022)	(0.016)
Rel. Pvt. Index				0.027	0.036	0.020
				(0.018)	(0.023)	(0.026)
Covariates	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Observations	2,914	1,457	1,457	2,914	1,457	1,457

Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01. This table examines the association between public, private, and overall measures of religiosity (measured through indexes) and political participation (measured as an index of turnout and active particiaption). Covariate adjustment is per the pre-specified procedure. FEs are a the randomization block. SEs are clustered at the randomization block level.

Consistent with prior research, I find religiosity—especially public religious practice—positively associated with political participation. A one standard deviation increase in religiosity is associated with a 0.16 standard deviation increase in participation (Table J.1). To test if religiosity moderates the impact of framing, I examine heterogeneous treatment effects from both experimental designs (Tables J.2 and J.3). I find religiosity predicts greater overall participation but does not weaken the distinct effect of the *seva* frame. In fact, religiosity modestly amplifies responsiveness to norm-challenging protest frames—particularly among men.

Table J.2: Heterogeneous treatment effects of religiosity on the effect of framing on exercising voice (Political communication experiment)

	Dependent variable:							
	Exercised voice							
	Pooled	Women	Men	Pooled	Pooled	Women	Men	Pooled
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Seva	0.034***	0.062***	0.008	0.007	0.034***	0.060***	0.010	0.009
	(0.012)	(0.018)	(0.016)	(0.016)	(0.012)	(0.018)	(0.016)	(0.016)
Rel Idx	0.022	−0.002	0.038*	0.043**				
	(0.016)	(0.026)	(0.020)	(0.020)				
Female				−0.070***				−0.067***
				(0.019)				(0.019)
Rel Pub Idx					0.036***	0.018	0.041**	0.048***
					(0.013)	(0.020)	(0.017)	(0.017)
Rel Pvt Idx					−0.018	−0.026	−0.005	−0.007
					(0.014)	(0.022)	(0.020)	(0.020)
Seva X Rel Idx	−0.014	0.018	−0.030	−0.035				
	(0.021)	(0.034)	(0.028)	(0.028)				
Seva X Female				0.055**				0.050**
				(0.023)				(0.023)
Rel Idx X Female				−0.046				
				(0.033)				
Seva X Rel Idx X Female				0.050				
				(0.045)				
Rel Pub Idx X Female								−0.029
								(0.026)
Rel Pvt Idx X Female								−0.021
								(0.030)
Seva X Rel Pub Idx X Female								0.020
								(0.035)
Seva X Rel Pvt Idx X Female								0.038
								(0.039)
Seva X Rel Pub Idx					−0.010	0.008	−0.011	−0.017
					(0.018)	(0.025)	(0.024)	(0.024)
Seva X Rel Pvt Idx					−0.004	0.013	−0.025	−0.023
					(0.018)	(0.028)	(0.026)	(0.026)
Covariates	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Observations	2,914	1,457	1,457	2,914	2,914	1,457	1,457	2,914

Note: **p<0.1;* ***p<0.05;* ****p<0.01* This table shows heterogenous treatment effects of religiosity on the effect of framing on exercising voice in the political communication experiment. Measures of public religiosity include participation in religious acts of service, visiting places of worship, attending religious storytelling sessions, and taking part in religious processions. Measures of private religiosity include a self-assessment of the importance of religion in respondents' lives, and the frequency with which respondents pray at home or watch religious programs. Estimates are based on OLS regressions with randomization block fixed effects and are adjusted for covariates. Standard errors are clustered at the randomization block level.

A potential concern is that the efficacy of the *seva* frame is merely a proxy for religiosity among BJP supporters. Figure J.1 addresses this by interacting religiosity, frame, and partisan alignment. The framing effect remains stable across levels of religiosity and for both BJP- and non-BJP-aligned respondents, suggesting the mechanism is not reducible to religiosity alone. In sum, while public religiosity fosters political engagement, it complements but does not substitute for norm-abiding frames.

J.2 Instrumental explanations

J.2.1 Welfare programs

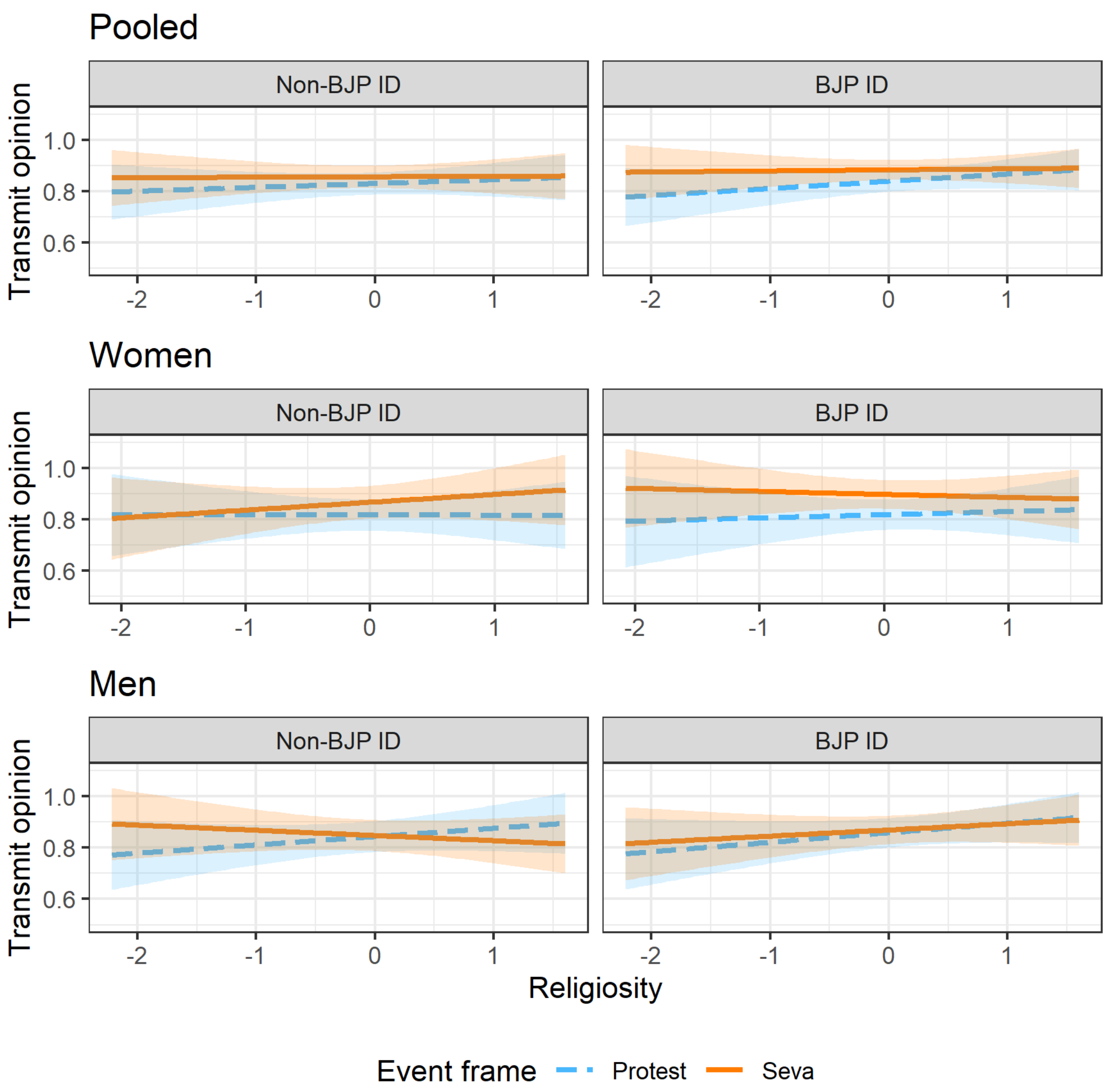
Parties may use welfare provision as a channel to influence vote choice and political participation. Since 2016, the BJP-led national government has targeted women through welfare offerings

Table J.3: Heterogeneous treatment effects of religiosity on the effect of framing on participation preference (Conjoint experiment)

	Dependent variable:							
	Profile choice				Profile rating			
	Pooled	Men	Women	Pooled	Pooled	Men	Women	Pooled
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Protest	−0.046***	−0.065***	−0.028*	−0.064***	−0.225***	−0.336***	−0.144*	−0.324***
	(0.012)	(0.017)	(0.016)	(0.016)	(0.060)	(0.089)	(0.081)	(0.089)
Seva	0.058***	0.068***	0.048***	0.068***	0.204***	0.305***	0.091	0.306***
	(0.012)	(0.016)	(0.016)	(0.016)	(0.059)	(0.088)	(0.078)	(0.088)
Religiosity	−0.025*	−0.016	−0.037*	−0.016	0.242***	0.451***	−0.014	0.459***
	(0.013)	(0.018)	(0.019)	(0.018)	(0.093)	(0.133)	(0.125)	(0.134)
Female				−0.005				0.257***
				(0.013)				(0.090)
Protest × Religiosity	0.048**	0.040	0.059*	0.040	−0.031	−0.244	0.222	−0.250
	(0.022)	(0.030)	(0.032)	(0.030)	(0.118)	(0.168)	(0.161)	(0.169)
Seva × Religiosity	0.025	0.007	0.050	0.007	0.017	−0.194	0.279*	−0.209
	(0.022)	(0.030)	(0.033)	(0.030)	(0.117)	(0.168)	(0.161)	(0.168)
Protest × Female				0.036				0.198
				(0.023)				(0.121)
Seva × Female				−0.020				−0.200*
				(0.023)				(0.117)
Female × Religiosity				−0.022				−0.481***
				(0.026)				(0.183)
Protest × Female × Religiosity				0.019				0.484**
				(0.044)				(0.233)
Seva × Female × Religiosity				0.043				0.499**
				(0.044)				(0.232)
FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Covariates	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Observations	11,656	5,828	5,828	11,656	11,656	5,828	5,828	11,656
R^2	0.008	0.012	0.005	0.008	0.023	0.034	0.029	0.027

Note: $^{*}p<0.1$; $^{**}p<0.05$; $^{***}p<0.01$ This table shows heterogenous treatment effects of religiosity on the effect of framing on profile choice and preference in the discrete choice experiment. Measures of public religiosity include participation in religious acts of service, visiting places of worship, attending religious storytelling sessions, and taking part in religious processions. Measures of private religiosity include a self-assessment of the importance of religion in respondents' lives, and the frequency with which respondents pray at home or watch religious programs. Estimates are based on OLS regressions with randomization block fixed effects and are adjusted for covariates. Standard errors are clustered at the individual level.

Figure J.1: Do religiosity and partisan alignment moderate the influence of framing?



Note: The figure shows how religiosity and partisan alignment moderates the effect of framing on exercising voice. Shaded regions indicate 95% confidence intervals.

such as subsidized gas cylinders, housing, toilets, and credit. Yet this strategy is constrained by incumbency: in opposition-ruled states like Rajasthan, the Congress-led government implemented similar schemes, limiting the BJP's credit-claiming advantage. Moreover, existing work suggests that program *receipt*, rather than *demand*, may be insufficient to catalyze women's political engagement (Kruks-Wisner (2018)).

Drawing on qualitative fieldwork, I focus on six flagship programs: the *Ujjwala* gas subsidy, the National Rural Employment Guarantee (NREGS) program, *PM-Awaas Yojana* housing, *Swacch Bharat* toilets, public pensions, and foodgrain rations. Coverage is extensive: 88% of respondents were aware of these programs, and the average household had accessed 2.33 of the six. Figure J.2 (top row) examines the relationship between welfare receipt and partisanship using covariate-adjusted fixed effects regressions. Contrary to conventional expectations, I find no consistent association between welfare benefits and support for either party, except for a weak pro-INC effect among male housing beneficiaries and female toilet recipients—even though the latter program was BJP-initiated. Similarly, welfare receipt does not predict higher political participation among women (bottom row). Female beneficiaries are no more likely to contact representatives than non-beneficiaries. In contrast, male recipients of NREGS and the *Ujjwala* gas subsidy show a greater propensity to voice preferences.

J.3 Structural explanations

Here, I examine two structural explanations: differences in candidate nomination patterns and variation in organizational activity across parties. The experimental design is not confounded by this. Moreover, it explicitly holds these factors constant by blocking on both the reservation status and partisan affiliation of the local representative. Hence, this section investigates whether these factors moderate the effects of framing.

J.3.1 Women's candidacy

Research shows that women's high-level candidacy can mobilize rank and file women into the organization (Goyal 2023). This suggests that differential elite candidacy patterns may drive women's mobilization by the BJP; however I find little partisan differences in national- and state-level nomination patterns. If anything, the INC nominated more women than the BJP since the 2009 national elections, peaking at 25% in 2014 (Figure J.3).

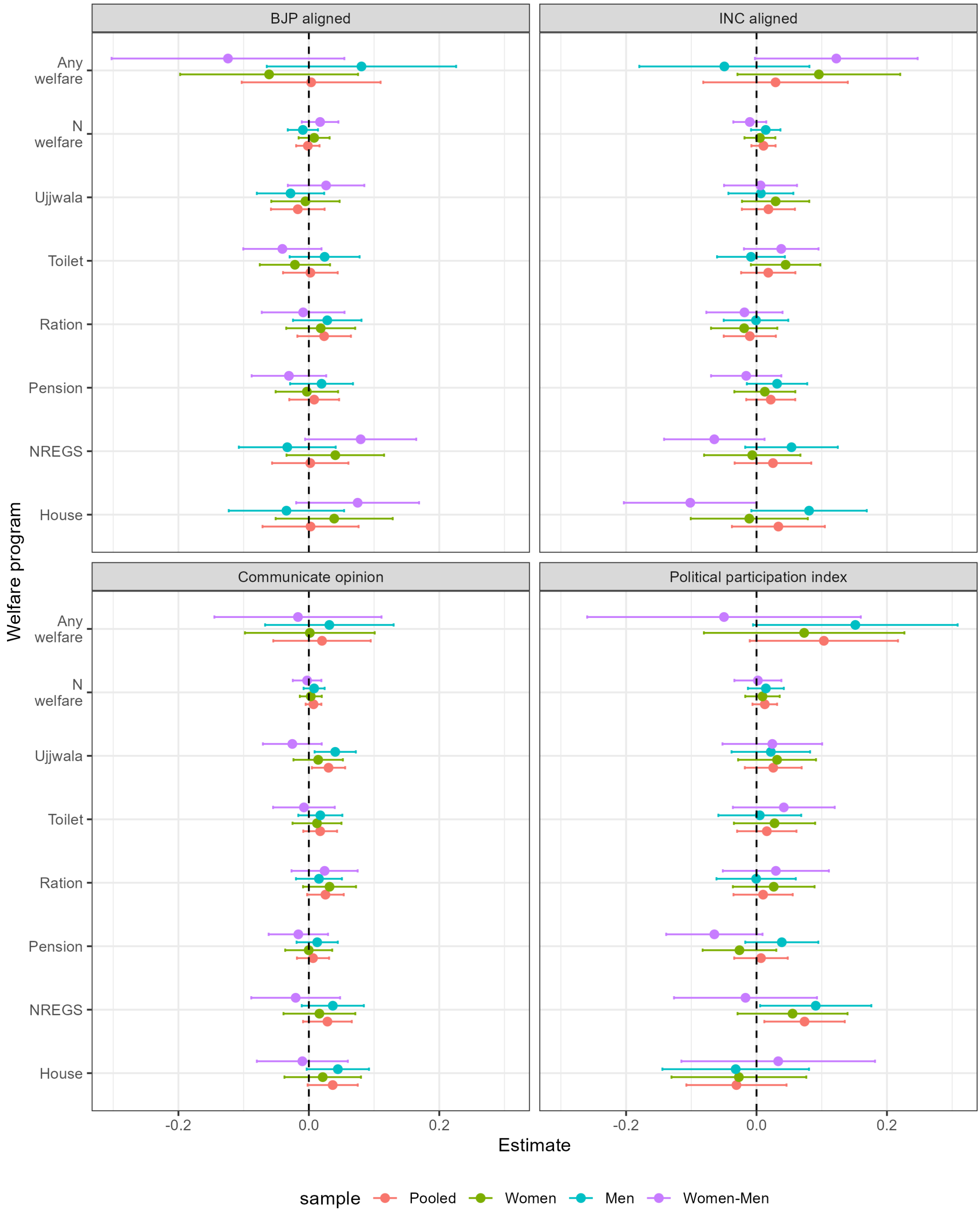
Moreover, reservations force both parties to nominate an equal proportion of women in local elections. In the 2019-21 municipal election cycle I find both the BJP and INC nominated ≈38% women, modestly exceeding the 33% quota. Their success rates in reserved wards were also comparable (43% for INC, 42% for BJP), suggesting limited explanatory power for party-level variation.

Finally, I do not find any evidence of women's greater participation through descriptive representation channels. Leveraging the representative-gender blocked design I test whether women are more likely to commuicate opinions in the presence of female representatives. Yet, Table J.4 shows null effects. In fact, men appear slightly less willing to engage with women representatives, though the difference is statistically insignificant. Together, these findings suggest women's candidacy and representation are insufficient explanations for observed partisan differences in women's mobilization.

J.3.2 Party organization

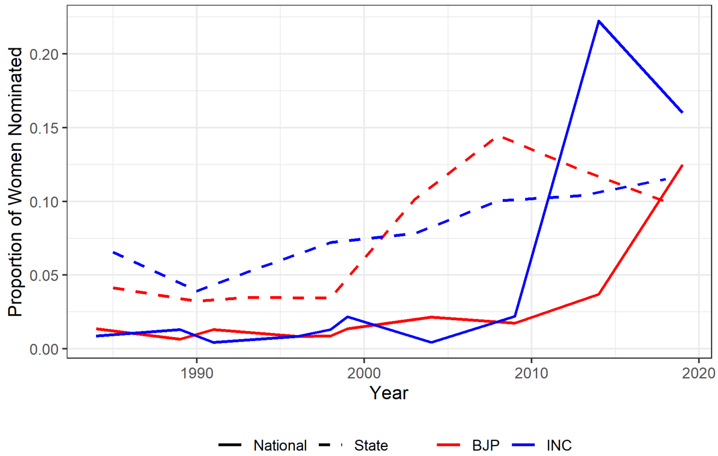
I examine two channels through which party organization might affect women's participation: the institutionalization of internal leadership positions, and the presence of local activists. Both parties adopted internal quotas for women but in practice, both fall short with widespread implementation failures (Ravi and Sandhu (2014); Williams (2023)). As one BJP activist noted:

Figure J.2: Effect of welfare benefits on partisan alignment and political participation



Note: This figure shows the association between welfare receipt and (1) partisan alignment (top row), and (2) political participation (bottom row) using covariate-adjusted estimates with randomization block fixed effects. "Communicate opinion" (exercising voice) is the dependent variable in the political communication experiment, and the political participation index combines electoral and non-electoral participation. Error bars indicate 95% confidence intervals. Standard errors are clustered at the randomization block level.

Figure J.3: Proportion of women candidates in BJP and INC (1981-2019)



Note: This figure shows the proportion of women nominated by the BJP and the INC to contest national and state-level elections in Rajasthan. Data is sourced from the Trivedi Centre for Political Data (Agarwal et al. 2021).

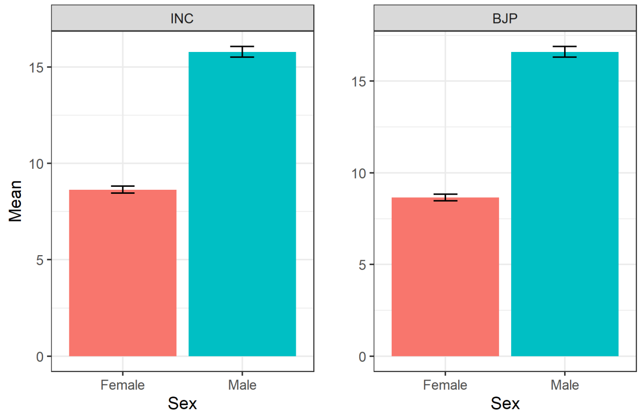
Table J.4: Does representative's gender shape voice expression?

	Dependent variable:									
	Exercised voice									
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)	(9)	(10)
F Rep	−0.021***	−0.011	−0.032***	−0.032**	−0.039***	−0.002	−0.005	−0.001	−0.007	−0.009
	(0.008)	(0.013)	(0.011)	(0.015)	(0.007)	(0.013)	(0.020)	(0.028)	(0.021)	(0.022)
F Resp				−0.053***						−0.033*
				(0.016)						(0.019)
BJP Rep							−0.004	−0.027	0.017	0.017
							(0.015)	(0.024)	(0.013)	(0.014)
F Rep X F Resp				0.019						0.008
				(0.027)						(0.034)
BJP Rep X F Resp										−0.041
										(0.029)
F Rep X BJP Rep							−0.032	−0.017	−0.050*	−0.045
							(0.026)	(0.041)	(0.029)	(0.030)
F Rep X BJP Rep X F Resp										0.024
										(0.053)
Covariates	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Sample: Resp sex	All	F	M	All	All	All	All	F	M	All
Sample: Rep Party	All	All	All	All	BJP	INC	All	All	All	All
Observations	2,914	1,457	1,457	2,914	1,446	1,468	2,914	1,457	1,457	2,914

Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01. This table tests the effect of gender and partisanship on exercising voice in the political communication experiment. FEs for Columns 1-4 are at the randomization block (Female reservation × Party × Region × District level) level, for Columns 5-6 are at the Party × Region × District level, and for Columns 7-10 are at the Region × District to avoid collinearity. SEs are clustered at the randomization block level. F Rep = Female representative, F Resp = Female respondent, BJP Rep = BJP representative.

“The next time they [party elites] tell you we reserve 33% seats for women, just ask them to count and show!”[6]

Figure J.4: Number of party activists



Note: This figure shows the organizational strength of the BJP and the INC based on respondents’ perception in their ward or Panchayat. Error bars indicate 95% confidence intervals.

A second organizational mechanism may be local activist presence. Using the household survey, I measured activist density by asking respondents how many active BJP and INC workers they could recall in their Panchayat or ward. When unavailable, responses were imputed using randomization-block means stratified by respondent sex. As shown in Figure J.4, both parties are organizationally matched within the sample: respondents reported an average of 8.6 women activists for each, and only a marginal BJP advantage among male activists (+0.8, $p < 0.05$). The gendered nature of political organizing in India suggests this male advantage is unlikely to produce large differences in women’s mobilization. However, this matching on organizational strength is partly by design as the sample blocked on the party of the local representative. This likely understates the BJP’s broader organizational advantage: beyond these sites, the BJP’s grassroots infrastructure, built through decades of RSS-affiliated service networks, likely extends further than the INC’s (Jaffrelot 1996; Mehta 2022). The null results on direct organizational effects should therefore be interpreted within this constrained sample rather than as evidence against an organizational role in the wider population.

Consistent with this, I find no evidence that organizational presence directly predicts political engagement within the sample (Table J.5). However, increased density of women activists moderates the visibility penalty for norm-challenging action particularly among INC respondents, while male activist density has negligible effects (Figure J.5). This null on the direct channel should not be read as evidence that organization is irrelevant. A distinct indirect channel, developed in the main text, operates through deployment: organizational infrastructure may matter less by directly mobilizing women than by expanding the reach of norm-abiding frames, raising the baseline of women contacted through whom *seva* framing can then do its work. To the extent that this indirect channel drives the BJP’s mobilizational advantage in the wider population—where its organizational reach is less constrained—the analyses here will underestimate its magnitude. While NAM remains the core proximate mechanism, its effectiveness at scale depends on the organizational capacity to deliver it.

[6] Interview, Jaipur, March 2019.

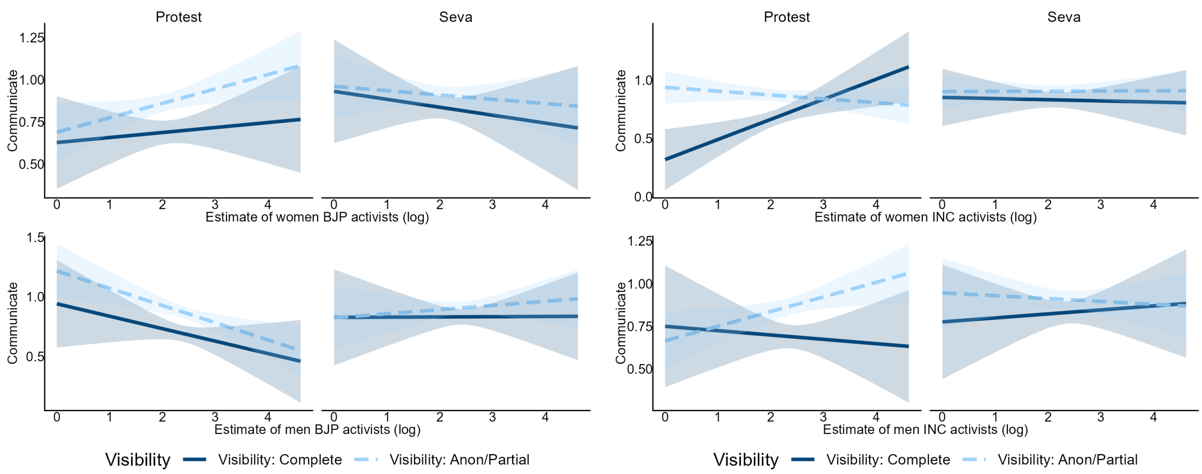
Table J.5: Does party organisation shape political participation? (Political communication survey)

	Dependent variable:									
	Communicated opinion									
	Women					Men				
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)	(9)	(10)
F activists	0.0002									
	(0.001)									
BJP F activists		0.001	0.002							
		(0.002)	(0.002)							
INC F activists				−0.0004	−0.0002					
				(0.002)	(0.002)					
M activists						0.0002				
						(0.0002)				
BJP M activists							0.0001	0.001		
							(0.0004)	(0.001)		
INC M activists									0.001	0.0002
									(0.0004)	(0.001)
BJP ID			0.038					0.032		
			(0.030)					(0.024)		
INC ID					0.028					0.032
					(0.034)					(0.025)
BJP F activists X BJP ID			−0.002							
			(0.002)							
INC F activists X INC ID					−0.0004					
					(0.003)					
BJP M activists X BJP ID								−0.001		
								(0.001)		
INC M activists X INC ID										0.001
										(0.001)
Covariates	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Observations	1,457	1,457	1,457	1,457	1,457	1,457	1,457	1,457	1,457	1,457

Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01. This table examines the association between organizational strength and opinion transmission in the political communication experiment. Covariate adjustment is per the pre-specified procedure. FEs are at the randomization block level. SEs are clustered at the individual level.

Figure J.5: How party organization influences the effect of visibility on political participation

(a) BJP (b) INC

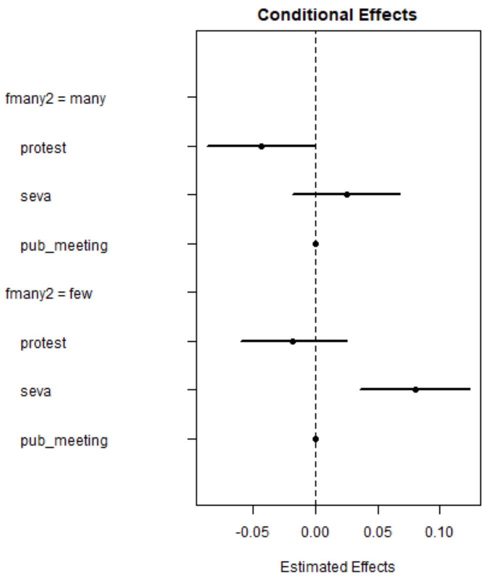


Note: The figure shows how party organization (log party workers) moderates the effect of visibility and framing on communication with representatives. Shaded regions indicate 95% confidence intervals.

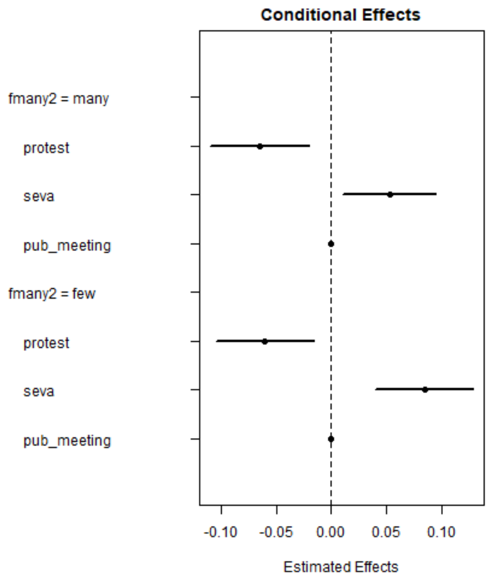
J.4 Behavioral explanations: Misperceived norms

A final explanation category is behavioral wherein updating misperceived norms can enable women's participation (Bursztyn et al. 2020). Applied here, this means that the *seva* advantage should attenuate when norm perceptions are already favorable, i.e., when many women are interested or many men are acquiescent, because in those conditions the norm information attributes are already supplying the correction the frame would otherwise provide. If, on the other hand, the *seva* advantage persists even under favorable norm conditions, this suggests that the frame is working through channels distinct from norm information correction.

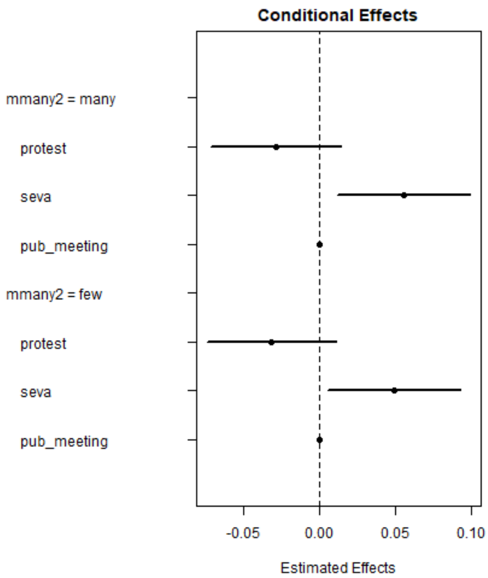
Figure J.6: Conditional effects by respondent and audience gender



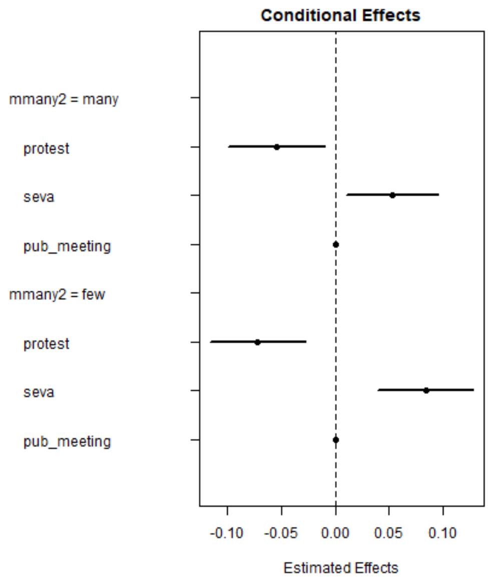
(a) Women respondents, women audience



(b) Women respondents, men audience



(c) Men respondents, women audience



(d) Men respondents, men audience

Note: This figure displays conditional effects across respondent and audience gender combinations.

Figure J.6 reports AMIE between the event frame and each norm perception attribute, separately for women and men respondents. Two patterns are notable. First, for women respondents, the *seva* advantage does attenuate when many women are perceived as interested (Panel A). This partial attenuation is consistent with a misperception account for the women's interest attribute — when peer participation is already perceived as high, the *seva* frame adds less. However, this pattern is also consistent with a ceiling effect: if women's baseline willingness to participate is already high when many peers are interested, there is simply less room for the frame to shift preferences, independent of any norm information mechanism. The two interpretations cannot be cleanly separated with the current design.

Second, and more importantly, no comparable attenuation is observed for the men's acquiescence attribute (Panel B). Since the social justification route operates through men's approval as the governing norm of women's participation, the stability of the *seva* effect across acquiescence conditions is inconsistent with a pure misperception account: if the frame were working only by correcting underestimates of men's permissiveness, its advantage should shrink when men's permissiveness is already revealed as high. It does not, suggesting that the NAM effects are not reducible to norm information correction.

Together, these patterns suggest that misperceived norms is at best a partial account of the framing effect. It may contribute to the sensitivity of women's preferences to perceived peer participation, but it cannot explain why NAM retains its advantage even when gatekeeper resistance is already signaled as low.

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